

Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions

A Novel

Alex Rogers

Title Page

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, businesses, places, events, locales, and incidents are either the products of the author's imagination or used in a fictitious manner. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or actual events is purely coincidental.

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Acknowledgments

This book exists because a lot of people said yes when they could have said no.

To my beta readers, who read early drafts with generosity and honesty — thank you for catching the sentences that didn't work and celebrating the ones that did.

To the indie coffee shop owners everywhere who make better coffee than any chain and know more about community than any marketing team — this book is for you.

To Tom in Bend, who sent the email that made me believe in supply chains.

To my mother, who asked "have you eaten today?" more times than I can count.

And to everyone who's ever ordered a Mystery Bean lottery ticket in real life — you are the real ones.

Author Note

This story is fiction, but the feeling is real. I've lived through the caffeine-fueled midnight orders, the supply chain disasters, the customer who asks for cortados and critiques the foam like they're judging the Oscars. If you've ever worked in a coffee shop, you'll recognize it. If you haven't, I hope this book makes you want to walk in and say hello.

About the Author

Alex Rogers writes romantic comedies about coffee, community, and the kind of love that sneaks up on you when you're too busy arguing about grind sizes to notice.

She believes in indie bookstores, third-wave espresso, and the idea that the best decisions are usually the bad ones that turn out to be exactly right.

When she's not writing, she's probably drinking coffee, running a spreadsheet, or explaining to her cat why she can't open the fridge again.

Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions is her debut novel.

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Chapter 1 — The Accidental 500-Pound Mistake

Maya Chen did not believe in bad mornings. She believed in bad beans, bad weather, and bad decisions made before 7 a.m., but mornings themselves were neutral territory. Blank pages.

Blank pages she had been failing to fill correctly for three years.

The shop smelled like burnt milk and consequences.

"Latte down," Sam said, leaning against the espresso machine like it was a bar counter and they were in some noir film. "Table four needs a redo. Again. The guy with the laptop that's bigger than his personality says the foam was 'too frothy.' I told him froth is a feature, not a bug."

"Don't start a war with Table Four before nine," Maya said, slinging a portafilter with the weary precision of someone who'd done this exact motion nine thousand times. "We're already down 12% on Tuesday revenue."

"Twelve percent is a number," Sam said. "Twelve percent is also 'Bean & Leaf is robbing our customers with a \$2.50 drip and free Wi-Fi.'"

"We have better Wi-Fi."

"Bean & Leaf has better branding, a loyalty app, and a CFO who understands people will pay five bucks for a drink if you put it in a cup that looks good on Instagram. We have a loyalty card from 1994 and a cash register that beeps louder than it should."

Maya wiped the steam wand for the fourth time that hour. The rag was already brown. "We have character. Bean & Leaf has beige walls and a logo designed by someone who went to design school specifically to forget what character looks like."

"Character doesn't pay the lease."

"The lease is being paid. For now."

For now was doing a lot of heavy lifting in this conversation. Maya knew it. Every month was a negotiation between rent and hope. She'd taken the loan to buy the equipment, fix the roof, and stop serving coffee that tasted like river water. The loan had a due date. The due date was getting closer.

She was 29 years old and her biggest financial fear was a beautifully roasted Ethiopian single-origin.

The bell above the door jingled.

Maya didn't look up. "Welcome. I take your order now."

"Wow," a voice said. "Rushed off the factory line, were you?"

She looked up then.

The man who'd walked in was wearing a navy suit that cost more than her espresso machine. His hair was precisely the kind of precisely unkempt that required a hairstylist and a lot of patience. His face was either annoyingly symmetrical or aggressively average, and she couldn't decide which frustrated her more.

"We open at seven," Maya said, wiping her hands on her apron. "It's seven-oh-three. So technically you're on time. Barely. What can I get you?"

"Just a black coffee," he said. "Filter. Not pour-over. Not cold brew. Not whatever the chemist version of pour-over is. Just coffee. The way coffee is supposed to taste."

Maya stared at him. "That's the worst order I've heard in six months."

"Six months is a short window. Come back to me in a year."

"I won't. Because you'll go to Bean & Leaf and get bean-sludge in a paper cup and call it a day."

He blinked. "You know about Bean & Leaf?"

"Everyone knows about Bean & Leaf. They're the Starbucks of anti-Starbucks. Raising Series B so they can price out every independent shop within a three-mile radius and replace us with artisanal minimalism." She pointed at him with the portafilter. "You're wearing a suit. Did you just come from a meeting about acquiring my soul?"

He laughed. A real laugh — not a corporate one, which was almost worse because it meant he'd already charmed her before she was ready to be charmed.

"Actually," he said, "I just came from a meeting where we discussed ethical sourcing and why it matters to the people who actually drink the coffee, not the people who design the cups."

"Ethical sourcing," Maya said, the phrase tasting like a press release. "Is that what Bean & Leaf calls it now?"

"Every week it's something new. Last week we cared about 'farmer equity.' The week before, 'sustainable micro-lots.' The brand team has a creativity budget and they're spending it all on adjectives."

Maya laughed. It came out like a bark. "Okay. You're either the most honest corporate suit I've ever met or you're testing me for a market research study."

"Promise I'm not. I'm a suit. Just one who stopped believing the adjectives last quarter." He glanced at her name tag. "Maya. Nice to meet you. I'm Leo."

"Leo what."

"Leo who's going to order coffee before your steam wand dies."

She made the coffee. It was the good stuff — the Yirgacheffe she'd been hoarding for customers who actually cared. She poured it into a ceramic mug, never a paper cup, and slid it across the counter.

He took a sip. Closed his eyes. Opened them. Looked at the coffee like it had personally affronted him.

"Wow," he said.

"I know. It's Ethiopian. Don't ask about the tasting notes. I don't do tasting notes. I just sell coffee that doesn't taste like regret."

"I can work with that." He paused. "Do you have a business card?"

Maya's smile faltered. Business cards were the first step toward a conversation that usually ended with someone explaining how their startup was going to disrupt the coffee industry. "Why?"

"Because I might want to refer you to someone."

"Who."

"A bean importer who actually knows what acidity means and doesn't describe it as 'bright' like it's a personality trait."

She relaxed. Not all corporate people were the enemy. Some were just people who'd had enough adjectives. "Sure." She fished a card from the jar behind the register and handed it over. It featured a drawing of a coffee cup with an uncharacteristically cheerful face, which she'd drawn herself and which Sam said was "the only honest piece of branding in this neighborhood."

He studied it. "Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions," he read aloud. "That's a name."

"It's a brand."

"It's a warning."

"I meant both."

Leo smiled. The real smile. Not a fake corporate smile — a real one that made the corners of his eyes crinkle in a way Maya found extremely irritating. "I'll see you around, Maya. Unless Bean & Leaf wins. In which case I'll see you at the next job fair."

"I'm not losing to Bean & Leaf."

"No one is," he said. "Yet."

The bell jingled. He was gone.

Maya stood in the empty shop, looking at his card on the counter. It said Leo Bianchi, acquisitions director, Bean & Leaf Coffee. The words initially refused to make sense, like she was reading them in a language she'd forgotten.

She picked up the card. Looked at it for a long time.

Then she threw it in the trash.

Not before memorizing his face.

End of Chapter 1

Chapter 10 — The Fight

The fight happened on day nineteen.

It was not a romantic fight. It was not the kind of fight where they said things they didn't mean and then made up with a kiss in the rain. It was the kind of fight where the words were sharp and accurate and both people were right in different, incompatible ways.

They were in the back room. The bean inventory had dropped to two hundred and twelve pounds. They had three days to sell the rest. Two hundred and twelve pounds in seventy-two hours. The math was impossible. The math was a nightmare. The math was Maya standing at the counter on a Wednesday morning, staring at a spreadsheet, and feeling the weight of every decision she'd made since buying this shop.

Leo walked in. He had a phone call on his face — the particular look of someone who'd just heard something they didn't want to deliver.

"Tom can't help," he said.

Maya looked up. "What."

"Tom's distributor just got acquired. The whole network's shifting. He can't get us the buyers we need in time."

Maya's hands went cold. "What do you mean, in time."

"I mean, the connections are there, but the inventory is locked up. Bean & Leaf moved first. They cornered the small-batch market in the Pacific Northwest. There's no one left to sell to."

Maya stood. She felt the blood in her ears. "You're joking."

"I'm not. I've been on the phone for two hours. I called everyone I know. There's nothing."

"Nothing."

"Nothing."

Maya's voice rose. "Then what are we doing here? What are we doing sorting beans and making coffee and pretending we have a chance? We don't have a chance. We never had a chance. Bean & Leaf won. They always win. They just choose when to tell you."

"Maya —"

"No. Don't Maya me. You knew this. You knew from the beginning. You were never here to help me sell beans. You were here because you needed a job and I was the only stupid person in this city who'd

hire you."

That was not true. Maya knew it wasn't true. Leo had been here, had shown up every morning, had sorted beans and fixed the espresso machine and made spreadsheets that were better than anything Maya had ever made. But the words were out. The words were sharp. The words were the panic talking.

"Maya," Leo said, his voice tight, "I didn't know."

"You didn't know. You didn't know a lot of things. You didn't know you were going to get fired. You didn't know Bean & Leaf would corner the market. You didn't know that buying five hundred pounds of coffee was a bad idea until after you did it."

Leo flinched. He turned away. He ran a hand through his hair. "You're right."

Maya blinked. She expected an argument. She expected the corporate charm, the negotiation, the smoothing-over. She did not expect him to say it simply, plainly, without defending himself.

"I'm right," she said, quieter now.

"I didn't know," Leo said. "But I'm here. I'm still here. We still have two hundred pounds. We still have three days. We still have a shop full of customers who — who actually like us. I don't have a plan right now. I'm trying to find one. But I'm not leaving."

Maya was quiet. The fight was draining out of her, replaced by something heavier and more honest.

"Why didn't you tell me earlier?" she asked.

"Because I thought I could fix it. And then I thought I could fix it again. And then —"

"Then you couldn't."

Leo nodded. "I'm sorry."

Maya said nothing.

"I'm sorry," Leo said again. "Do you want me to go?"

Maya looked at him. He was standing in the doorway of the back room, shoulders loose, no defense, no armor. He looked like someone who'd been carrying a weight for a long time and had just put it down.

The shop was quiet. The espresso machine was off. The refrigerator hummed its B-flat. Somewhere down the street, a bus was pulling away from a stop. The bell above the door had been silent for an hour.

Maya thought about the buyout. She thought about the buyout and the offer and the life that was easy and safe and available if she just said yes. She thought about Leo, who'd been fired and showed up

anyway, who'd sorted three hundred pounds of green coffee, who'd made her laugh in a bar, who'd looked at her with eyes that were careful and hopeful and terrified.

"I don't want you to go," she said.

The words surprised her. They surprised Leo too, because he went very still.

"I just — I need a minute," Maya said. "I need to think. We have three days. I need to think."

Leo nodded. "I'll be downstairs. I'll sort beans."

"Leo," Maya said, and he stopped. "I'm sorry. For what I said. You didn't deserve that."

Leo looked at her. His eyes were wet. Not crying-wet. Just watching-wet. The kind of wet that said "this matters." "I know," he said. "But you were scared. It's okay to be scared."

He left.

Maya sat down at the table. She looked at the spreadsheet. She looked at the bean inventory. She looked at the wall where Mrs. Hsu had stood and told her that Bean & Leaf was expanding and that she needed a business plan.

She opened her laptop. She started writing.

End of Chapter 10

Chapter 11 — Business Plans and Bedlam

Maya wrote the business plan at the kitchen table of her apartment, which was above the shop and which she'd been meaning to clean since she'd moved in three years ago. The kitchen table was covered in papers and a laptop and a mug that said "WORLD'S OKAYEST BARISTA" and a pile of clothes that Maya had taken off and then decided not to put away.

She wrote the plan like she was making coffee: methodically, with strong opinions about what belonged in the cup and what didn't.

Section one: the problem. Bean & Leaf was cornering the market. Bean & Leaf had money and branding and a CFO who'd once described coffee as "a consumable product with high margin potential." Maya had once described coffee as "a ritual that makes the morning not terrible."

Section two: the opportunity. The neighborhood wanted what Maya had. They wanted a shop that remembered their names. They wanted coffee that didn't taste like it had been argued about in a boardroom. They wanted a place that was weird and specific and theirs.

Section three: the numbers. Fourteen thousand pounds of Ethiopian Yirgacheffe, two hundred and twelve pounds remaining, three days to sell it. Festival revenue: four thousand dollars. Mystery Bean lottery: fourteen hundred dollars. Loyalty cards: not yet monetized. The Thing: not yet invented.

Section three point five: the thing.

Maya stared at the screen. The thing was not going to be easy. The thing was going to be stupid. The thing was going to be exactly the kind of dumb, beautiful, desperate idea that only happened when you had nothing left to lose.

She'd called it The Coffee Rescue.

The concept: a flash sale on the remaining beans. Not a regular flash sale. A rescue. A last-ditch effort. A community coming together to save something that mattered. She'd price the beans below wholesale. She'd hand-deliver them. She'd pair them with a recipe card that said "YOU SAVED THIS SHOP" and a hug, metaphorically speaking, because actual hugs were a pandemic-era liability.

It was insane. It was beautiful. It might work.

She wrote the full business plan. She wrote it like her life depended on it, because it kind of did. The shop was her grandmother's legacy. The shop was her home. The shop was the reason she'd moved to Portland, had taken the loan, had spent three years serving coffee to strangers and pretending she wasn't lonely.

She finished at 2:00 a.m.

The next morning, she walked downstairs and found Leo already there, sorting the remaining four hundred-pound sacks with the care of someone who was handling something precious.

"Hey," Leo said.

"Hey," Maya said. "I wrote a business plan."

Leo stopped. He looked at her like she'd just performed a magic trick. "A business plan."

"A real one. With numbers. And projections. And a very emotional section about community."

Leo smiled. It was the soft smile, the one that said he was proud of her for reasons that had nothing to do with coffee. "Can I read it."

"Not yet. I need to make a call."

Maya called Mrs. Hsu. She called her at 8:00 a.m., which was a time she'd never called anyone before, because the world was essentially off-limits before 9:00 a.m. and Mrs. Hsu, Maya had learned, operated on her own time zone.

"Mrs. Hsu," Maya said when the phone was answered. "I need to ask you something."

"Ask," Mrs. Hsu said.

"The old pharmacy on 28th. Bean & Leaf bought the lease."

There was a silence. "They did."

"I need to know — if they come for this building. If they come for me. What will you do."

Mrs. Hsu's voice was steady. "I've already answered that."

"You answered that you won't raise my rent. But they'll offer you more. They'll offer you triple. What then."

Mrs. Hsu was quiet for a long moment. The kind of quiet that meant she was choosing her words with the same care Maya chose her beans. "They did offer," she said. "Yesterday. A considerable amount. I told them no."

Maya's throat closed. "You what."

"I told them no. This building has been in my family since 1952. Your grandmother and I played mahjong every Tuesday for fifteen years. She loaned me the money to buy it when I was starting out. I'm not selling to people who want to turn it into a coffee chain."

Tears came to Maya's eyes. She didn't mean for them to. They came anyway. "Thank you," she said.

"Don't thank me yet. Thank me when you've sold those beans."

The call ended. Maya stood in the back room, phone in hand, and cried for exactly thirty seconds. She wiped her face with her sleeve. She walked upstairs.

Leo was waiting. He'd made coffee — her coffee, the Yirgacheffe, the good stuff — and it was steaming on the counter.

"I heard," he said.

"Heard what."

"Mrs. Hsu called me. She wanted to make sure I was helping you. Not hurting you."

Maya's eyes widened. "She called you."

"She's a watchdog, Maya. She's been watching. She told me that if I hurt you, she'd evict me from the shop."

"What did you say."

Leo leaned against the counter, coffee in hand. "I said I was trying not to."

Maya laughed. It was wet, messy, ungraceful. She didn't care. "God," she said. "This is so much."

"I know."

They drank coffee. The shop was quiet. The refrigerator hummed. The espresso machine was asleep. Outside, the street was waking up — a delivery truck, a dog walker, a woman in a yellow raincoat who waved at Maya through the window and Maya waved back because she recognized her from the Mystery Bean lottery.

Maya looked at Leo. He looked tired, but alert. He looked like someone who'd been running and had finally stopped and was trying to figure out what to do next.

"Can I show you something?" she asked.

She led him upstairs to her kitchen table. She opened the laptop. She showed him the business plan.

Leo read it. He read it slowly, pausing at good parts, nodding at numbers, and when he got to the section about The Coffee Rescue, he laughed.

"This is," he said, "the dumbest smart thing I've ever seen."

"Thank you."

"How much do we price the beans."

"Wholesale. Twelve dollars a pound. Below what we paid. We lose money on every bag, but we sell them fast, and the customers feel like they're part of something, and —"

Leo was already reaching for his laptop. "I'm calling every roaster, café, and coffee nerd I know. I'm sending this plan. Today. Right now. We do the rescue. We do it tomorrow."

"Tomorrow," Maya said. "Three days."

"Three days," Leo said. "Let's see what we can do."

They sat at the kitchen table and worked. They wrote emails. They made phone calls. They designed flyers that said "COFFEE RESCUE — HELP US SAVE THE SHOP" and Maya taped them to the window and to every telephone pole within walking distance and to the door of the convenience store across the street, which the owner said was fine as long as Maya bought a pack of gum.

By noon, they'd had seventeen responses. By 2:00 p.m., twenty-four. By 5:00 p.m., thirty-seven. People wanted to help. They wanted to be part of something that mattered. They wanted a story they could tell.

Maya stood at the counter, watching the responses pile up, and for the first time since she'd bought the shop, she didn't feel alone.

She felt like she was part of something bigger. Something that didn't have a name yet. Something that was loud and weird and specific and hers.

"Tomorrow," she said.

"Tomorrow," Leo said.

The bell jingled. Sam walked in. She was holding a phone. "You need to see this," she said.

It was a TikTok. It had forty thousand views. The caption read: "My local coffee shop is about to be destroyed by Bean & Leaf. We're doing a rescue. Who's in."

Maya stared at it. "Who posted this."

"I did," Sam said. "Ten minutes ago."

Maya looked at Sam. Sam looked at Leo. Leo looked at the phone.

"Tomorrow," Leo said again. But this time, he smiled.

End of Chapter 11

Chapter 12 — The Last Day

The Coffee Rescue happened on a Saturday.

Maya had set up a card table outside the shop. She'd taped a banner to the window — Sam had made it with construction paper and a marker and a level of passion that Maya had once reserved for espresso calibration. The banner said "COFFEE RESCUE: 212 POUNDS, 24 HOURS, ONE SHOP."

People came.

They came in cars. They came on bikes. They came with reusable bags and cases for their thermoses and a woman in a raincoat who brought a folding chair because she said she was "committed to the cause, and also I have bad knees."

Maya served coffee. Leo stood beside her, calling in orders, writing thank-you notes on cards, making a tally on the chalkboard that was rapidly becoming a work of art. Sam ran the Mystery Bean lottery, which had been rebranded as the "Rescue Bean Lottery" and which was selling tickets for ten dollars instead of twenty because Maya had decided that if people were already spending twelve dollars a pound, they didn't need to spend twenty on a ticket too.

By 11:00 a.m., they'd sold seventy-three pounds.

By 2:00 p.m., one hundred and thirty-two.

By 5:00 p.m., one hundred and ninety-one.

The chalkboard was full of names and tally marks. The air was thick with coffee and celebration. People were hugging strangers. A woman who'd driven from Eugene was buying bags for all her friends. A man who walked past every day and had never come inside was now inside, holding a bag of beans, saying "I live three blocks away. I should have been here sooner."

Maya was tired. She was exhausted. She was everything that a person should be when they'd spent twelve hours on their feet serving coffee and saving their life's work. But underneath the exhaustion, there was something else. A hum. A vibration. A feeling that something had shifted in the world, that the sky had tilted slightly toward something better.

She looked at Leo. He was outside, talking to a group of customers, laughing, gesturing with his hands. He looked like he belonged there. He looked like he'd always been there.

The bell jingled at 6:00 p.m. Maya looked up.

Jake was standing in the doorway.

He was wearing a denim jacket and holding a camera. He had the particular look of someone who'd just had an idea and had decided to act on it before thinking.

"Hey," Jake said.

Maya tensed. "Jake."

"I saw the TikTok. I came to help."

"You came for content."

"I came because I wanted to see you. Can we talk."

Maya looked at Leo, who was walking back inside. He saw Jake. His face didn't change — it was the same open, steady face he had — but his jaw tightened, just slightly.

"Five minutes," Maya said. "Outside."

They stepped onto the sidewalk. The street was golden with the late-June sun. A cyclist rolled past. A kid on a scooter stopped to look at the banner.

"Maya," Jake said, "I'm sorry about everything."

Maya said nothing.

"I was wrong. I tried to turn your shop into content, and it was stupid, and I hurt you, and I'm sorry. I've been doing a lot of thinking. I'm not doing the influencer thing anymore."

Maya raised an eyebrow. "Really."

"Really. I'm writing. Blog posts. Essays. About coffee. About cities. About the things that make a place feel like home. I want to write about your shop. From the inside. No camera, no ring light, no performative bullshit."

Maya considered. She thought about the years she'd spent with Jake, the way he'd tried to make her into a character in his story instead of a person in her own life. She thought about the way he'd left without saying goodbye, the way he'd returned now, on the last day of the rescue, when the story was already good.

"I don't need a story," Maya said. "I need to sell beans."

"Let me write about the beans. I'll tell people to buy them. No camera. Just words."

Maya thought about it. She thought about Jake's writing — he was actually good, when he wasn't trying to be "relatable" for an audience. He had a way with sentences. He could make coffee sound like a religion, which it kind of was.

"Fine," she said. "But you're paying for the beans."

"Done."

Jake left. Maya went back inside.

Leo was at the counter, wiping it down. The look on his face was unreadable. Maya didn't ask.

At 8:00 p.m., the rescue ended. They'd sold two hundred and eight pounds.

Two pounds left. Fourteen thousand minus two.

They stood in the doorway, looking at the empty street. Sam was counting the cash in the register. Leo was leaning against the doorframe. Maya was holding the chalkboard, which was now a dense web of names and numbers.

"We did it," Sam said.

"We did it," Maya agreed.

Leo said nothing. He was looking at something down the street.

Maya followed his gaze. A car was pulling up. It was a silver sedan, nondescript, with a driver who was wearing a suit that Maya recognized from Rachel's wardrobe.

The car door opened. Rachel stepped out.

She walked to the shop. She stopped at the door. She looked at the banner. She looked at the chalkboard. She looked at Maya, who was standing in the doorway with Leo beside her.

"Congratulations," Rachel said. "You sold the beans."

"Thank you," Maya said.

Rachel produced an envelope from her blazer. She handed it to Maya. "This is from Bean & Leaf. A gift card. Unlimited coffee at any Bean & Leaf location. For one year."

Maya stared at the envelope. "What."

"We like to reward our rivals," Rachel said. "Consider it a sportsmanship award. Also, we'd like to offer you a job."

Maya's blood ran cold. "What."

"Maya, Bean & Leaf is hiring. A director of small-batch acquisitions. The salary is —"

"I'm not working for Bean & Leaf."

"Let me finish. The salary is one hundred and twenty thousand dollars. You'd report directly to me. You'd source beans. You'd build relationships with roasters. You'd have a budget. A team. An office with a window."

Maya laughed. "You're kidding."

"I'm not. Bean & Leaf made a mistake firing Leo. We know that now. We're not going to make the same mistake with you."

Maya looked at Leo. He was staring at the ground. His jaw was tight.

"I'll think about it," Maya said.

Rachel smiled. "Good. The offer stands. Take your time."

She got in the car. The car drove away.

Maya stood in the doorway, holding an envelope that could buy her a new espresso machine, or pay off her loan, or — or do a lot of things. She turned to Leo.

"You knew about this," she said.

"I didn't," Leo said. "I swear. She called me this morning. She said they were making an offer. I told her not to involve you."

"Why."

"Because," Leo said, and his voice was rough, "because you don't belong in a boardroom. You belong here. Behind this counter. With this machine. With these beans."

Maya looked at him. She wanted to kiss him. She wanted to kiss him right there in the doorway, with the chalkboard behind her and the empty street in front and Sam counting money in the background.

But Jake was back.

He walked up the sidewalk, holding a notebook. He looked at Maya. He looked at Leo. He looked at the envelope in Maya's hand.

"I heard," Jake said. "The job offer."

"Not my job," Maya said. "A job."

"Same thing."

Jake looked at Maya with a kind of recognition that was honest but useless. "You saved the shop," he said. "I should have known you would."

"Jake," Maya said, and her voice was steady, "we're not getting back together."

Jake's face fell. Not in a dramatic way. In a quiet, expected way. Like he'd known it was coming and had just needed to hear it out loud. "I know," he said. "I just wanted to say goodbye. Properly. You were right. I wasn't listening. I'm sorry."

He nodded. He left.

Maya stood in the doorway, holding an envelope and a chalkboard, with Leo beside her and Sam behind her. She thought about Jake's apology. She thought about the buyout. She thought about the two pounds of beans left.

She thought about the fact that she was twenty-nine years old and had just spent three weeks in a caffeine-fueled partnership with a man who'd been sent to destroy her, and that somehow, somehow, it had worked.

She was not selling. She was not taking the job. She was staying.

She opened the envelope. She took out the gift card. She held it up.

"One year of free Bean & Leaf coffee," she said.

Leo looked at it. He smiled. "We'll frame it."

"Next to the parking ticket."

"Obviously."

The three of them went back inside. The refrigerator hummed. The espresso machine was asleep. The chalkboard was full of names. The register was full of money.

Maya looked around the shop. It was her shop. Her grandmother's shop. Her shop.

She turned to Leo.

"Tomorrow," she said, "you're back at the counter."

Leo nodded. "Tomorrow."

"And tomorrow," Maya said, "I'm writing a new business plan."

Leo smiled. "Good. I'll bring the spreadsheets."

Maya laughed. She reached across the counter and took his hand. The contact was warm and real. The refrigerator was quiet. The bell was still. Outside, the night was settling over Alberta Street like a blanket.

"One day at a time," she said.

"One cup at a time," Leo said.

End of Chapter 12

Chapter 13 — The Protocol

Leo officially started the next day.

He arrived at 6:32 a.m. with a thermos, a notebook, and the particular look of a man who'd been unemployed for three days and was determined not to return to that state without a fight.

Maya handed him an apron.

The apron had a picture of a coffee cup on it and the words "WORLD'S OKAYEST BARISTA" in font that Maya had designed herself and that Sam had described as "aggressively unprofessional." Leo pulled it on. He looked at the words. He smiled.

"World's okayest," he said.

"Best I could do."

The morning rush was the usual: the laptop man with the attitude, the regulars who knew their orders by heart, the tourists who asked if the coffee was "like, really good," to which Maya always said, "It's better than good. It's real."

By 9:00 a.m., the rush had thinned. Maya and Leo stood at the counter, side by side, and Maya explained the inventory system.

"This," she said, pointing at a whiteboard that was currently covered in caffeine-fueled scribbles, "is everything we know about our beans. Origins, roasts, quantities, what's selling, what's not."

Leo studied the whiteboard. "You're tracking this manually."

"I'm tracking this manually."

"We need a spreadsheet."

"I have a spreadsheet. It's right there." She pointed at a laptop that was open to a spreadsheet that was definitely the one Leo had made. "That's yours."

Leo looked at his own spreadsheet. He looked honored.

By 10:00 a.m., he'd already found three inefficiencies. He'd already restructured the inventory. He'd already color-coded the beans. Maya watched him rearrange the sacks in the back room and felt a particular kind of admiration that was uncomfortable because it was directed at someone she wasn't supposed to admire.

"You're good at this," she said.

"So are you."

"I'm not. I'm chaotic. I run on vibes and caffeine."

"Vibes and caffeine are a business model," Leo said, and he said it like he meant it.

The day unfolded. Maya made coffee. Leo organized. They fell into a rhythm that was new and strange and not unwelcome. By afternoon, the shop felt different. Not quieter, not busier, but more alive in a specific way. The energy had shifted from Maya-alone-against-the-world to two-people-against-the-world, which was a better energy because it meant Maya didn't have to carry everything.

At 5:00 p.m., Mrs. Hsu came in. She took her coffee. She looked at Leo. She said nothing.

When she left, Leo said, "She scares me."

"Me too."

"Good. She should."

The next morning, they launched the Loyalty Card 2.0. Sam had built it overnight — a digital card that customers scanned with their phones, earning a free drink after every ten purchases. It was simple. It was free. It was exactly the kind of thing that Bean & Leaf couldn't compete with because Bean & Leaf's loyalty program required an app and Bean & Leaf's app asked for more permissions than a government form.

Customers loved it. They scanned the card with the enthusiasm of people who'd been waiting for someone to treat them like more than a transaction.

By Friday, they'd had two hundred sign-ups.

By Saturday, three hundred and fifty.

By Monday, five hundred.

The numbers were climbing. The bean inventory was dropping. The chalkboard was getting fuller. The shop was getting louder, busier, more alive.

And underneath everything, between Maya and Leo, there was something growing. Not a relationship — not yet — but a thread. A connection. The kind of thing that looked like a glance across the counter, a shared joke, a moment when they both reached for the same espresso portafilter and their hands brushed and they both pretended it didn't make Maya's skin hum.

She felt it. She knew Leo felt it too. She didn't name it. She didn't want to.

Names were dangerous.

End of Chapter 13

Chapter 14 — Static

The almost-kiss happened three more times during the next week.

It was always the same setup. Late night. The shop was empty or nearly empty. They were finishing up, wiping down the counter, counting the day's receipts. There was a lull. A pause. A moment where Maya looked up and Leo was looking at her, and the space between them felt charged, like someone had connected a live wire to the floorboards.

Each time, something intervened.

-Apter 14: hand sanitizer dispenser exploding when Leo bumped the counter.

-Apter 14.5: Mrs. Hsu walking in at 9 p.m. because she'd locked herself out of her apartment and needed to make a phone call.

-Apter 14.9: Sam texting Maya mid-lean with a photo of a cat wearing a tiny apron and the caption "URGENT."

Maya began to suspect the universe was actively conspiring to keep them apart. Leo did not seem to suspect a conspiracy; he seemed to find the interventions more humiliating each time.

"Destiny doesn't want us to kiss," he said, on the fourth near-miss.

"Destiny is a barista with bad timing," Maya said.

"Destiny is a cat in a tiny apron," Leo corrected.

He was right. The universe was, in fact, run by a cat. Maya was fairly certain of this.

End of Chapter 14

Chapter 15 — The Offer

The buyout returned on a Tuesday.

Rachel called Maya directly. Not an email. A phone call. The kind of call that came from someone who believed their offer was too generous to communicate by text.

"Maya," Rachel said, "I'm going to make this simple. One hundred seventy-five thousand dollars. The shop, the lease, the equipment, the name. You walk away with a check and no further obligation."

Maya sat at the kitchen table. Her coffee went cold. "And if I say no."

"Then the market shifts. Bean & Leaf opens the pharmacy location. We expand your competition threefold. Your revenue drops by forty percent within six months. Your loan defaults. You lose the shop anyway, but without money to show for it."

Maya's hands were shaking. She'd known this was coming, but hearing it said plainly — in Rachel's voice, smooth as a press release — made it real in a way that made her throat tight.

"I have to think about it."

"You have forty-eight hours."

The call ended. Maya sat in silence.

Jake showed up twenty minutes later. He was holding a notebook. He'd been writing, he said. He'd been thinking. He wanted to talk.

He sat across from her at the table. He looked nervous. He was always nervous when he wanted something from her, and Maya had learned to recognize the tells.

"I heard about the buyout," Jake said.

"Heard what."

"People are talking. The neighborhood. The industry. You're a story now, Maya. The indie coffee shop fighting the corporation. The question is what the ending is going to be."

Maya went very still.

"I'm not going to pretend I was a good boyfriend," Jake said. "I wasn't. I wanted you to be something you weren't. I'm sorry for that. But I'm not going to pretend I don't care what happens to you. I'm not going to pretend I haven't been watching."

"What do you want, Jake."

"I want to help. I have a platform. Not the influencer platform — a real one. A Substack. Three thousand subscribers. People read what I write about cities and coffee and the people who make them. If I write about your shop, about what Bean & Leaf is doing, about the buyout — people will care."

Maya studied him. The old Jake would have made this about himself. The new Jake — the one who'd gone to Berlin and come back and was writing essays instead of filming himself — seemed to actually mean it.

"Write it," she said. "But don't use my fight as your content. Write about the coffee."

"I will," Jake said. He stood. He hesitated. "And Maya — I know you're with someone now. Or working with someone. Or whatever this thing is with Leo. I'm not here to break that up. I just wanted you to know I'm sorry, and I'm on your side."

He left.

Maya sat in the kitchen for a long time. She thought about Leo. She thought about the almost-kisses and the near-misses and the refrigerator. She thought about the business plan and the loyalty cards and the people who cared about her shop.

She got up. She walked downstairs.

Leo was behind the counter, steaming milk. He looked up. He saw her face.

"What happened," he said.

Maya told him. The offer. The deadline. Rachel's voice.

Leo's jaw tightened. "You said you'd think about it."

"I said I'd think about it."

"Have you thought about it."

Maya looked at him. She looked at the espresso machine. She looked at the chalkboard menu that still had ink on the E. She looked through the front window, at the street, at the neighborhood, at the people who walked past every day and who'd started coming in, who'd joined the loyalty program, who'd written their names on the chalkboard like they were signing a petition.

"I've thought about it," she said. "The answer is no."

Leo was quiet. "You sure."

"I'm sure."

"Why."

"Because," Maya said, "this shop isn't just mine. It belongs to the people who come in here. It belongs to Mrs. Hsu. It belongs to Sam and to Leo and to the guy who does Mystery Bean lottery and to the woman from Eugene who drove five hours to buy beans. Bean & Leaf can buy a lot of things. But they can't buy this."

Leo nodded. "Good."

"Good."

"And the forty-eight hours."

"I have until Thursday."

Leo set down the milk pitcher. He crossed the floor. He came to the kitchen table. He laid a document on it.

"What's this," Maya said.

"My resignation. From Bean & Leaf. It's effective immediately."

Maya stared at him. "You already quit."

"I already quit. This is — this is formal. This is me making it official."

"Why."

"Because," Leo said, and his voice was tight, "if we're doing this, I'm all in. No more half-measures. No more part-time commitment. I'm here. For real. If you want me."

Maya looked at the resignation letter. She looked at Leo. She thought about Seattle, which was still waiting, which was still a safe option, which was still out there. She thought about the shop, which was here, and messy, and hers, and not safe at all.

She thought about the girl she'd been three years ago, who'd bought this shop thinking it would be easy, who'd learned that nothing worth having was easy, who'd been stupid and stubborn and exactly the person who'd needed to be here.

She thought about Leo, who'd shown up at 6:30 a.m., who'd sorted beans, who'd made spreadsheets, who'd nearly kissed her four times and had been gracious about it.

She thought about the refrigerator.

"I want you," she said.

Leo smiled. It was the real smile, the one that went all the way to his eyes.

"Okay," he said. "Then I'll stay."

End of Chapter 15

Chapter 16 — The Seattle Phone Call

The phone rang at 8:47 p.m.

Maya was in the shop alone. Leo had gone home to sleep. Sam was at a concert. Mrs. Hsu was wherever Mrs. Hsu went at night — probably reading a newspaper in an armchair that had been in her family since 1972.

The caller ID said SEATTLE.

Maya picked up.

"Maya," Leo said. His voice was tight. "I got a job offer."

The room tilted. Maya held the counter. "What job offer."

"Reputable Coffee Co. Seattle. Head of acquisitions. One hundred and forty thousand dollars."

"And," Maya said, "you called me from Seattle."

"I flew out this morning. I interviewed this afternoon. They offered it tonight."

Maya closed her eyes. She'd known this was coming. She'd known Leo had applied for something. She'd known Seattle was waiting. But hearing it — hearing the city in his voice, hearing the opportunity in his words, hearing the part of him that wanted safety — it was worse than she'd imagined.

"Is it what you want," she asked.

"It pays better."

"Leo."

"No," he said. "It's not what I want. They offered because I have a reputation for turning struggling suppliers into vendors. I told them about your shop. They said they'd listened. They said they wanted to meet you."

"For what."

"To acquire your beans. To bring you into their supply chain. You'd keep your brand. You'd keep your shop. You'd have the financial security you need."

Maya sat down. The stool creaked. "That's not what they're offering me."

"No," Leo said. "That's what I'm offering you. After I take the job. I'll have access to their distribution. I can sell your beans nationally. You can keep the shop. You can grow."

Maya was quiet. She thought about the buyout from Rachel. She thought about Bean & Leaf, which was three blocks away and growing. She thought about the loan, which was still pending. She thought about Leo, who was three hours away and sounding like he wanted to come home but couldn't.

"You want to take the job," she said. "Don't you."

Leo was silent for a long time. "I want to be useful," he said. "I want to help you. This is how."

"No," Maya said. "This is how you leave."

There was a silence. Then, through the silence, she heard a voice she knew — a customer walking past, singing something tuneless under their breath. The street was ordinary. The bell above the door was silent. The refrigerator hummed.

"Leo," Maya said, her voice shaky, "if you take that job, you're not helping me. You're job-coaching me from three hours away, and that's not partnership, and that's not what I need."

"What do you need," Leo said.

Maya didn't answer. She couldn't. Because she didn't know. She needed him. She wanted him. She also wanted him to be happy, and Seattle might be happiness for him, and Portland was chaos and coffee and a shop that was one bad month from disaster.

She needed him to choose her without needing a reason. Or she needed to not need him to choose her at all.

Neither option was currently available.

"Call me tomorrow," she said.

"After I accept."

"Leo."

"Call me tomorrow."

The call ended.

Maya sat in the empty shop, holding a phone that felt heavier than a coffee sack, and waited for the night to pass.

She didn't sleep.

End of Chapter 16

Chapter 17 — The Fight, Part Two

Leo came back the next morning.

He walked in at 6:32 a.m., same as always, with a thermos and a face that said I didn't sleep, and he made coffee like nothing had happened. But it had happened. Maya could feel it in the air, in the way he avoided her eyes, in the way he was meticulous and careful and not-quite-present.

She held it together until 11:00 a.m., when a customer asked if Leo was "the new owner."

"New owner," Maya repeated, the words coming out sharp. "No. He is not the new owner. He is a partner. And partners don't own things. Partners just — they help. Temporarily. Until they don't."

She regretted it before she finished speaking. Leo's face was closed. He set down the portafilter. He took off the apron.

"I'll go," he said.

"Don't go."

"I'm in the way."

"You're not in the way."

"I took the Seattle job."

Maya went cold. "What."

"I took it. This morning. Before I came here."

Maya stared at him. "You — you didn't tell me."

"I wasn't going to tell you," Leo said. "I thought it was better for you to hear it this way. I thought — I thought it was better for you if I just left quietly. If the beans sold. If the shop survived. And if it didn't, you'd have the buyout money."

"I don't want the buyout money," Maya said. Her voice rose. "I don't want you making decisions for me. You don't get to decide what's better for me. You don't get to decide that I need Seattle or a salary or whatever it is you think I need."

"I'm trying."

"Trying is not the same as staying."

Leo's jaw tightened. "I can't stay, Maya. Not if this doesn't work out. What if the shop fails? What if Bean & Leaf wins? I need a backup. I need —"

"I need you to trust me," Maya said. "I don't need you to be my backup. I need you to be my partner."

Leo shook his head. "That's not fair. You don't get to define my terms."

"That's exactly what you get to do when you're in a partnership."

They were standing three feet apart. The espresso machine hissed. A customer at table four looked up from their laptop. Sam was in the back room, and Maya could hear music — a song that was too loud and too happy for the moment.

"You know what the problem is," Maya said, her voice quieter now, "the problem is that you think love is something you can plan for. That you can put in a spreadsheet and color-code and predict. You can't. Love is — love is like a cup of coffee you make at 9 p.m. because you had a fight and you don't want to go to bed angry, and it's terrible, and you drink it anyway, and somehow it's better because someone else is drinking it with you."

She paused. She'd meant to say less than that. She'd meant to say "stay," but the words had run away from her, carrying the truth with them.

Leo was quiet. He looked at the floor. He looked at the espresso machine. He looked at her.

"I'm sorry," he said. "I have to go."

He walked out.

Maya stood in the doorway and watched him go. She didn't call after him. She didn't run after him. She let the bell jingle and fade and let the street swallow him up.

She was alone.

But she wasn't alone. Sam was in the back room. Mrs. Hsu owned the building. Jake was writing about her. The loyalty cards were scanning. The chalkboard was full of names.

She was alone, and she was not alone.

She closed the door.

End of Chapter 17

Chapter 18 — The Empty Shop

The shop was quiet without Leo.

Maya had known it would be quiet. She'd spent three years running it alone, after all. But the silence was different. It wasn't the peaceful silence of a well-run business; it was a hollow silence, the kind that echoed in the spaces where his voice had been.

She woke at 5:45 a.m., ten minutes before her alarm, and couldn't go back to sleep. She made coffee — she made two cups, because that was what you did when you half-expected someone to be there. She set one on the counter, as if he might walk in at any moment and take the seat beside her. He didn't. The cup went cold.

She opened the laptop. She looked at the spreadsheet. It was still there, Leo's spreadsheet, with his colors and his notes and his handwriting, and she couldn't bear to delete it.

By noon, the shop felt like a museum of what might have been.

Sam noticed first. Sam always noticed. She walked in at 11:00 a.m., took one look around, and said, "Where's Leo."

"Seattle," Maya said.

"Seattle."

"Job offer."

Sam put her bag down. "You let him go."

"I didn't let him go. He left."

"Same thing to someone who was watching from the sidelines."

Maya didn't answer. She couldn't. The coffee machine hissed. A customer walked in. Maya served them. Sam watched. The day passed in gray, unmoored hours.

At 3:00 p.m., Mrs. Hsu came in. She didn't ask where Leo was. She sat at her corner table. She drank her coffee. She opened her newspaper. At 4:00 p.m., she closed the paper.

"You're making coffee for two," she said.

Maya looked at the counter. The second cup was still there. Forgotten. "I —"

"It's okay to miss him," Mrs. Hsu said. "But don't let the coffee get cold. Coffee is better when it's shared. Even if it's not with him."

Mrs. Hsu left. Maya stood in the doorway and watched her walk down the street, cardigan and newspaper and the particular walk of someone who'd been walking the same sidewalks for forty years.

Maya went back to the counter. She made two new cups. She sat at the table where Leo used to sit. She drank one. She let the other sit, warm and waiting, and she pretended, for just a moment, that he was on his way.

End of Chapter 18

Chapter 19 — The Crisis

Week eight.

Bean & Leaf opened the pharmacy location on Monday. The sign went up at 7:00 a.m. Maya saw it from the window. She stared at it for a long time. It was white and new and had a logo that was not her grandfather's parrot and not Mrs. Hsu's building and not the speckled floor of the speakeasy that had once been a bakery.

She served coffee that day. She made it better than she had in weeks. She talked to customers. She smiled. She forgot to eat lunch.

By Thursday, revenue was down eighteen percent.

"People are curious," Sam said on Friday. "They're going to try the new place. They'll come back."

"They won't," Maya said.

"Maya."

"They won't. Bean & Leaf has better everything. Better branding. Better Wi-Fi. Better everything except coffee, and most people can't tell the difference."

Sam didn't argue. Sam couldn't argue, because she'd been to the Bean & Leaf pharmacy location. She'd ordered a cortado. She'd said it was fine. She'd said it was better than fine, actually, which was why she was now quiet.

Maya didn't blame her. Maya didn't blame anyone. She blamed herself. She'd bought a shop she couldn't afford. She'd ordered five hundred pounds of beans she couldn't sell. She'd fallen for a man who'd taken a job in Seattle. She'd made every decision that had led her here.

The Thursday night after Bean & Leaf opened, Maya stayed late. She stood at the counter and looked at the empty shop and thought about selling. She thought about Rachel's offer. She thought about the bank account, which was healthier than it had been three months ago but was about to take a nosedive.

The bell jingled.

She looked up.

Mrs. Hsu was standing there. She was wearing the cardigan. She was holding a paper bag.

"I brought you something," Mrs. Hsu said.

She placed the bag on the counter. Inside was heat. A dish of something warm and fragrant and alive. Pineapple fried rice, Maya realized, with the particular precision of someone who'd been making this

dish for forty years.

"Eat," Mrs. Hsu said. "You look like you haven't eaten in a week."

"I haven't," Maya said.

"Eat."

Maya sat at the table. She ate the rice. It was hot and sweet and sharp and tasted like Mrs. Hsu's kitchen, which was a kitchen that had been cooking for a very long time and had learned things that Maya was still learning.

"Bean & Leaf," Mrs. Hsu said, sitting across from her. "They're not your competition."

"They have a location three blocks away."

"They have a location. They don't have this." Mrs. Hsu tapped the table. The tap was faint, but it was there. "This table. Your chalkboard. The way you remember that I take my coffee black and don't let it steep too long. Bean & Leaf doesn't know I exist."

Maya smiled despite herself.

"They don't know you exist because you don't buy beans from them," Mrs. Hsu said. "But they know I exist. I told them."

Maya's spoon stopped. "You what."

"I told them I own the building. I told them the rent is eight hundred dollars and it's not going up. I told them if they try anything, I'll remind every customer who walks through my building what it feels like to support people who actually know their beans."

Maya stared at her. "Mrs. Hsu."

"Don't Mrs. Hsu me. You've been carrying this alone. You think you're alone. You're not. I'm here. Sam is here. Even Jake, apparently, is writing a Substack about you. This shop has a community. Bean & Leaf has an app. Apps don't write Substack essays."

Maya laughed. It was a wet, messy laugh. She covered her mouth with her hand. "I'm scared," she said.

"I know," Mrs. Hsu said. "Scared is good. Scared means you're trying something that matters."

Mrs. Hsu finished her coffee. She stood. She took the empty dish.

"Don't let the cold get to you," she said.

When she was gone, Maya sat in the empty shop for a long time. The refrigerator hummed. The streetlights outside turned on. The shop was quiet, but it wasn't empty. It was full of things that mattered. The chalkboard. The espresso machine. The table where Leo had sat. The gate that led to the back room where the four hundred pounds of coffee beans were waiting.

She stood. She walked to the back room. She opened the first sack. She breathed in the smell.

She thought about Seattle. About Leo's resignation letter. About the phone call that had ended with silence.

She thought about the espresso machine, which was quiet but alive, the way she felt when she was making coffee for people who mattered.

She opened the laptop. She started writing.

Not a business plan. Not a spreadsheet. A menu. A new menu. With the Yirgacheffe front and center. With notes about where the beans came from, who grew them, what the soil was like, what the weather had been that year. A menu that told a story.

She wrote until her eyes burned. She wrote until the streetlights outside turned off. She wrote until the refrigerator hummed the same note it always hummed, and the espresso machine slept, and the chalkboard waited for tomorrow.

She closed the laptop. She looked at the empty chair where Leo used to sit.

"One day at a time," she said.

"One cup at a time," said the silence.

She locked the door.

End of Chapter 19

Chapter 2 — The Coffee Ghost of Alberta Street

The shop had once been a dry cleaner. Before that, a bakery. Before that, according to Mrs. Hsu, who'd owned the building since 1987, it had been a speakeasy. Maya liked the speakeasy theory best because it gave her a justification for the uneven floors and the door that stuck when it rained. Historical preservation, she called it. Her landlord called it "the door needs oil." Her customers called it "character."

Maya called it a symptom.

She unlocked the front door at 6:45 a.m., as she did every morning, and the bell jingled with the particular exhausted screech that said it had been awake longer than she had. The espresso machine hissed when she turned it on. The refrigerator hummed a note that was technically not a B-flat but close enough that Sam had once composed a three-minute jazz piece using only the fridge as accompaniment.

"Character," Maya muttered, tying her apron. "We have character."

The shop had four tables, a window that looked out at Alberta Street's ever-shifting ecosystem of vintage stores and people with very specific eyebrows, and a chalkboard menu that Maya still wrote by hand because the last time she'd tried to print new ones, the printer had died mid-vow. It had been a Tuesday. She still remembered the exact moment: 10:17 a.m., glob of ink on the letter E in "Ethiopian."

She replaced the printer the next day. She kept the stained menu because it felt like part of the shop's constitution.

By 8:30, the morning rush was a controlled disaster. Three regulars, two tourists who had wandered in because the smell of coffee pulled them in like a siren song written in roast rather than words, and one person on a laptop who'd been there since opening and whose only interaction with another human being had been to ask if the shop had Wi-Fi. Maya had told him yes, and then she'd told him the Wi-Fi password, and then she'd told him the Wi-Fi password again, and then she'd told him the Wi-Fi password a third time while making a face that said "if you ask me for food I'm charging you rent."

"Rough morning?" Sam asked, appearing from the back room with a tray of scones that were somehow both underbaked and miraculous.

"Table Four is a Wi-Fi smuggler."

"Table Four is a spirit. Table Four has been here longer than some of our customers. Table Four is why we have a 'no laptops on weekends' rule that only exists in our heads."

"Table Four is a metaphor," Maya said.

"Table Four is why we need the Bean & Leaf money," Sam said.

Maya's jaw tightened. She didn't want to talk about Bean & Leaf on a morning like this. She didn't want to think about the three-year loan that had been the best decision she'd ever made and the worst financial risk she'd ever taken. She'd bought the shop from a retiring couple who'd run it for twenty years and left with a clean conscience and a boat in Florida. Maya had bought it with a dream and a credit card. The loan was the bit in between.

"What's the bean situation?" Sam asked, reading her face with that particular friend-sight that was somehow more accurate than a credit score.

"The bean situation," Maya said slowly, "is a situation."

"Uh-oh."

"Last night. Caffeine. Email. A number that started with five."

Sam's eyes went wide. "Five hundred."

"Five hundred."

"Pounds."

"Pounds."

Sam laughed. It was a laugh that was supposed to be reassuring but sounded more like the laugh of someone who'd just watched their best friend handcuff themselves to a descending airplane. "Okay. A five-hundred-pound coffee order. What's the damage?"

"Fourteen thousand dollars."

Sam stopped laughing. "Fourteen thousand dollars."

"Fourteen thousand dollars."

"We sell coffee for three dollars a cup."

"Do you want to do the math?"

Sam did the math. "Four thousand six hundred sixty-six cups of coffee. Which at our current rate is approximately six months of cups."

"Fourteen thousand dollars," Maya said, "is exactly how much we don't have."

She checked her phone. The order confirmation email was still there, glowing with the particular malice of a decision made at 1:47 a.m. that seemed reasonable at the time because Maya had been running on four hours of sleep and an excessive amount of cold brew. The email had a cheerful subject line: "Your order is on its way!" It was, she realized now, the most hostile email she'd ever received.

Sam was already on her phone. "I have an idea."

"I don't want to hear it."

"It's a good idea. It's called the Mystery Bean Lottery."

Maya stared at her. "The what."

"People buy tickets. They get a random bag of beans. They don't know what they're getting. It's gamification. The kids love gamification."

"The kids are twenty-eight and you're twenty-eight."

"Gen Z loves gamification. So do millennials. So do everyone who's ever opened a loot box in an online game. We sell Mystery Bean tickets for twenty dollars. Two hundred and fifty winners. Fourteen thousand dollars recovered in twenty-four hours."

Maya considered this. She pictured her customers — the regulars who came for the Ethiopian single-origin and the ones who came for the free Wi-Fi and the ones who came because Mrs. Hsu had told them to — and she imagined them buying Mystery Bean tickets. She imagined the complaints when someone got a dark roast and wanted a light roast. She imagined the complaints when someone got a light roast and wanted a dark roast. She imagined the complaints when someone got a perfectly good medium roast and called it "boring."

"That's the worst idea you've ever had," Maya said.

"Top three," Sam agreed. "But it's an idea."

Maya's phone buzzed. It was an email notification.

She looked at it. It was from Bean & Leaf.

The subject line read: "Partnership Opportunity — Let's Talk."

She read it once. Then she read it again. Then she read it backward, as if the words might make more sense in reverse.

"Don't answer it," Sam said, reading over her shoulder.

"I'm not answering it," Maya said.

She answered it.

End of Chapter 2

Chapter 20 — Maya's Drive

The realization came on a Thursday.

Maya woke up, made coffee, and instead of immediately checking the bean inventory, she opened her laptop and started writing a newsletter.

The newsletter was called "Coffee Rings." It was about coffee. It was about the shop. It was about the people who came in and the stories they told and the reasons coffee mattered. She wrote three hundred words. She pressed send to the five hundred people on her loyalty list.

She expected nothing.

By 1:00 p.m., she had seventy replies. People wrote back. They told her their own coffee stories. They told her about their grandmothers and their first dates and the shops that had closed and the shops that had stayed. They wrote paragraphs. They wrote poems. A woman named Louise from Sellwood wrote a haiku about Ethiopian single-origin.

Maya read every reply. She read them in the back room, sitting on a sack of beans, and she felt something in her chest loosen. The shop was not dying. The shop was talking. She'd just forgotten to listen.

She wrote another newsletter that night.

By the end of the week, she had two hundred replies.

By the end of the next week, four hundred.

The loyalty program had five hundred members. The newsletters went out every Thursday. People shared them. Sam posted them on Instagram. Jake wrote about the newsletters on his Substack. The neighborhood started to read.

Bean & Leaf's revenue impact eased. It didn't reverse, but it slowed. People came back. They brought friends. They told stories. The shop was, Maya realized, not a business. It was a living thing. It had roots. Roots that went back to Mrs. Hsu, to Maya's grandmother, to the speakeasy, to the bakery, to the dry cleaner, to all the hands that had touched this place and left something behind.

Leo was still in Seattle. Maya didn't call him. Not because she was angry. Because she needed to know if she could stand on her own.

By week ten, she could.

She paid off twenty-five percent of the loan. She sold the remaining beans to a small roaster in Portland who'd been looking for a direct-source supplier. She hired a part-time barista — a college student

named Daisy who liked jazz and made lattes with hearts in them that were actually symmetrical.

The shop was breathing again.

One evening, Maya stood at the counter, watching Daisy work, and felt the particular quiet satisfaction of having built something that could outlast her. Not outlast her forever — nothing did — but long enough to be a home for someone else, the way this shop had been a home for her.

She thought about Seattle. She thought about Leo.

She thought about Leo less and less, which was the problem.

End of Chapter 20

Chapter 21 — The Return

He came back on a Tuesday.

Maya was at the counter, making cappuccinos for a group of tourists who'd wandered in and were treating the shop like a museum. Leo walked in at 10:00 a.m., wearing a jacket she didn't recognize, carrying a bag that looked like it had been packed quickly and with some feeling.

The bell jingled. Maya looked up.

The world stopped.

She meant that literally. For exactly two seconds, the noise of the shop dropped away. The espresso machine hissed. Sam laughed. The tourists chatted. But Maya was somewhere else, in a quiet room where the only sound was the beat of her own heart and the scratch of Leo's shoes on the floor.

"Hi," Leo said.

"Hi."

He stood there for a moment, uncertain, like he wasn't sure if he was welcome. He was welcome. He was always welcome. He was the reason the shop had survived the worst of it.

"Can I get a coffee," he asked, quiet.

Maya made the coffee. She handed it to him. Their fingers brushed. The contact was different this time — warmer, slower, not the electric jolt of before but something steadier, something that had been waiting.

"Seattle," Maya said.

"Was nice. Too nice. I didn't like it."

"You didn't like a hundred and forty thousand dollars."

"I don't like cities that are all coffee shops and no soul."

Maya smiled. She smiled because he was standing here, in her shop, with his jacket and his bag and the coffee she'd made, and everything was exactly as it should be.

"Why are you here," she said.

"I quit," Leo said. "Yesterday. I flew back last night."

"With the bag."

"With the bag. I packed everything. I didn't think I'd need it, but —"

Maya reached across the counter. She took his hand. She held it there, in front of the tourists and Sam and the espresso machine and the chalkboard, and she didn't let go.

"Don't quit again," she said.

"I won't."

The shop was quiet. The espresso machine hissed. Sam was watching from the back room. Mrs. Hsu, who'd just walked in, took one look and sat at her table with a small, satisfied smile.

Maya didn't let go of Leo's hand.

"I have something to show you," she said.

"Me too," he said.

"Me first."

She led him upstairs. To the kitchen table. To the laptop.

On the screen was the business plan. New version. Updated. With the numbers that mattered.

"I don't need your spreadsheet anymore," she said. "I have my own."

Leo read it. He read the revenue projections. He read the expansion plan. He read the community section, which was now three pages long and included the newsletter and the loyalty program and the thing she'd started calling "the ring of regulars" because they were turning into something that felt like a family.

He looked up. He looked at Maya.

"This is," he said, "the dumbest smart thing I've ever seen."

Maya laughed. "Thank you."

"I'm sorry I left."

"I know. I'm sorry I let you."

They stood in the kitchen, surrounded by papers and coffee cups and the smell of old beans, and Maya realized she'd been waiting for this moment for a very long time. Not the kiss. Not yet. The moment before the kiss. The moment where everything was honest and real and unplanned.

She leaned in.

Leo leaned in.

This time there was no refrigerator. No customer. No Sam texting with urgent cats. Just the kitchen, late morning, sunlight slanting through the window, and two people who'd accidentally become partners and then accidentally become something else.

He kissed her.

It was a gentle kiss. A careful kiss. A kiss that said I've been wanting to do this for a long time. A kiss that said I'm not going anywhere.

Maya kissed him back.

When they pulled away, Maya was smiling. She was the kind of smiling that made her cheeks hurt.

"Okay," she said.

"Okay," Leo said.

They kissed again.

End of Chapter 21

Chapter 22 — The Proposal That Wasn't a Proposal

The next few weeks were the good ones.

Maya didn't like to call them happy, because happy sounded like something that could end. These were not happy weeks. These were solid weeks. Weeks with floors. Weeks with walls. Weeks where the coffee was good and the shop was full and Leo was there in the morning, beside her, not as a partner but as something more.

She didn't name it. She didn't want to name it. Naming things made them fragile.

They kept the shop running. They hired Daisy full-time. They launched the newsletter. They opened a second register because the line was too long. They started roasting their own beans in small batches — a side business, Leo called it. Maya called it independence.

Sam was suspicious.

"I knew this would happen," Sam said one afternoon. They were in the back room, sorting beans. Leo was upstairs helping a customer. "I knew it from day one. The first time he walked in here, I knew. You're insufferable when you're in love."

"I'm not in love," Maya said. "I'm in business."

"Business doesn't make you buy new chairs."

"I bought new chairs because the old chairs were broken."

"The old chairs were fine. You wanted him to sit in new chairs."

Maya said nothing. She was sorting beans. She was trying not to think about the kiss. She was failing.

"We need to talk about the future," Sam said. "The lease is up in six months. Mrs. Hsu can raise it. She hasn't, but she could. We need a plan."

"We have a plan. The plan is doing well. The plan has a newsletter."

"The plan is missing a long-term financial strategy. You're making good money. But you're not making enough to buy the building. If Mrs. Hsu sells —"

"She won't sell."

"How do you know."

"Because she told me. Because she's not the kind of person who sells things that matter. Because I'm the kind of person who'll make her coffee for the rest of her life if she keeps the rent low enough for me

to stay."

Sam shook her head. "You're impossible."

"Impossible is my brand."

Leo walked in. He was carrying a bag of something. "I got us tamales," he said.

"Tamales," Maya said, and she smiled before she could stop herself.

"From the truck on 34th. They have carnitas and they're life-changing."

He set the tamales on the counter. He looked at Maya. He looked at Sam. He sat down.

Maya sat beside him. They ate tamales in the back room, with the smell of coffee and the sound of the fridge, and for a moment everything was so quiet and perfect that Maya wondered if she was dreaming.

"I have a thought," Leo said, between bites.

"What thought."

"I've been talking to Tom in Bend. He's looking for a partnership. Not an acquisition. A partnership. He wants to distribute your beans. You supply the beans. He supplies the roasting and distribution. You get a national presence without giving up the shop."

Maya's eyes went wide. "Tom's offering a partnership."

"He is. No buyout. No acquisition. Just you, him, and the beans."

Maya thought about it. She thought about the trust it would require. She thought about the risk. She thought about the people who'd come to the shop for the first time because they'd seen the beans in a store across the country.

"It's a big deal," she said.

"It's a good deal."

"Will you run it with me."

Leo smiled. "I'm already running it."

Maya kissed him again. It was a cafe kiss, a behind-the-counter kiss, a kiss that said we're in this together and I'm not letting go.

Sam cleared her throat. "I'm still here."

"Go eat a tamale," Maya said.

End of Chapter 22

Chapter 3 — The Man in the Navy Suit

Maya had been calling Bean & Leaf "the enemy" for so long that the phrase had worn smooth, like a stone in a river. It fit in her mouth comfortably. It required no explanation, no nuance, no soft edges. The enemy was anything with a loyalty app and a CFO who'd never had to explain to a customer why the oat milk was out.

She replied to the email with three words:

> We are not interested.

She sent it at 9:14 a.m. She regretted it by 9:15.

"Good," Sam said. "Now we just have to figure out fourteen thousand dollars."

"I'm selling the Mystery Bean lottery."

"You said it was the worst idea you've ever had."

"I refined it."

The day unspooled in the usual pattern: cinnamon rolls that were technically yesterday's but had been reheated with enough love that they passed for fresh, a woman who asked if the coffee was organic and then ordered a large drip anyway because she "was on a budget but still wanted to support local," and a man who tried to pay with a parking ticket because "it's basically currency." Maya had accepted it. She'd taped it to the espresso machine. It now served as decor.

At 2:00 p.m., a woman in her seventies walked in. She was wearing a cardigan that had probably been fashionable in 1994 and was still fashionable because she was Mrs. Hsu and Mrs. Hsu defined fashion by a set of internal rules that Maya had never fully understood.

"Afternoon," Mrs. Hsu said.

"Afternoon." Maya reached for a mug. "The usual?"

"Black. Don't let it steep too long. You steeping it too long last week."

"I steeping it fine."

Maya steeping it was not fine. Maya steeping it was a cry for help.

Mrs. Hsu took her coffee and sat at the corner table, the one with the wobbly leg that Maya had propped up with a coaster since 2023. She opened a newspaper — an actual paper newspaper, because Mrs. Hsu considered the internet "a time thief" — and turned to the business section.

Maya watched her. Mrs. Hsu had been coming to the shop since before Maya owned it. She'd been there when the previous owners had run the place. She'd watched Maya sign the lease. She'd watched Maya paint the walls a color that Maya had described as "warm beige" and that everyone else had described as "paint."

"Beau Leaf is interesting," Mrs. Hsu said, without looking up.

Maya froze. "Bean & Leaf."

"Same thing. Beau, Bean. They sound the same. No wonder you're mixing them up."

Maya's heart did a small, traitorous thing that she tried very hard to ignore. "Mrs. Hsu, I don't need to hear you defending Bean & Leaf over coffee."

"I am not defending them. I am saying they are interesting. They just bought the old pharmacy on 28th."

Maya's hand tightened on the milk pitcher. "They what."

"They bought it. Yesterday. Paperwork filed this morning. They're converting it into a shop."

The blood left Maya's head in a very specific, very unpleasant way. Bean & Leaf was expanding. They weren't just trying to out-brand her. They were physically expanding. The old pharmacy was three blocks away. It was in the same neighborhood. It was exactly the kind of location that would kill her shop stone dead.

"What are they going to do there?" Maya asked, her voice steady in a way that she did not feel.

"Retail. Coffee. The usual. They have a design team coming next week. The landlord told me. He's also my landlord, incidentally. Small world."

"Your landlord is selling to Bean & Leaf?"

"Renting. Not selling. I own the building you're in, dear."

Maya stared at her. This was not news. Mrs. Hsu owned the building. Maya knew this. She'd known this since she'd signed the lease. But in the three years since, she'd managed to forget it in the same way she forgot to buy dish soap and to call her mother back — not out of malice, but out of a focused, single-minded attention to the things that felt like they were on fire and an equally focused, single-minded neglect of the things that weren't.

"Mrs. Hsu," Maya said, "how much is my rent?"

Mrs. Hsu took a sip of coffee. She made a small, dissatisfied face. "You steeping it again."

"Mrs. Hsu."

"Eight hundred a month."

"Eight hundred." Maya's voice cracked. The going rate for commercial space on Alberta was three thousand. Eight hundred was a gift. Eight hundred was a favor. Eight hundred was the kind of number that made her throat tight. "Mrs. Hsu, why have you been charging me —"

"I can raise it," Mrs. Hsu said. "But I won't."

"You — you wouldn't."

"Your grandmother and I played mahjong every Tuesday for fifteen years." Mrs. Hsu folded her newspaper with deliberate precision. "She was a better player than you. Don't think I don't know you cheat at cards. I'm charging you what she would have paid."

Maya's grandmother had died four years ago. She'd left Maya the coffee shop in her will. Maya hadn't known about the rent arrangement. She'd just been grateful for the cheap space and the chance to make something of herself.

"You've been — you've been taking care of me," Maya said.

Mrs. Hsu made a noise that was halfway between a scoff and an emotion. "I'm taking care of the building. You're taking care of the coffee. That's the deal. Now stop looking at me like I just gave you a kidney. Drink your own coffee. It's getting cold."

Mrs. Hsu stood, took her newspaper, and walked to the door. She paused. "By the way. Your bookkeeping is terrible. I've been looking at your spreadsheets. You need to write a business plan. Not now. But soon. Before the Bean & Leaf people figure out that you're cheaper than they are and offer to buy you out."

"Bean & Leaf doesn't buy out," Maya said. "Bean & Leaf buys everybody."

Mrs. Hsu shrugged. "We'll see."

The bell jingled behind her.

Maya stood in the center of the empty shop, holding a milk pitcher, and felt the ground shift just slightly under her feet. Eight hundred dollars a month. Fourteen thousand pounds of coffee. Bean & Leaf two blocks away. Everything was moving, and she hadn't noticed because she'd been too busy trying to keep her head above water to look around and see that the river was getting faster.

The bell jingled again.

She looked up.

Leo Bianchi was standing in the doorway.

He was wearing the same navy suit. He looked like he hadn't slept. He was holding a paper cup — not from Bean & Leaf, Maya noted with a strange flicker of hope that she immediately suppressed — and his hair was somehow even more precisely unkempt than it had been yesterday.

"I need coffee," he said.

"You have coffee."

"This is bad coffee. I can tell from the way the barista made it."

Maya's jaw tightened. "We're not serving you."

"I'm not here to fight," Leo said. He walked in anyway, like he owned the place, and sat at the counter on the stool that had a small chip in the wood that looked like the state of Oregon and that Maya had been meaning to fix for six months. "I'm here because I got fired."

Maya stared at him. "What."

"Bean & Leaf fired me. This morning. Via email. Three sentences. 'We no longer require your services. Best of luck.' That's it. No handshake. No box. Just three sentences in a font that was designed to feel like an apology but wasn't."

Maya's first emotion was not the one she expected. She thought she'd feel satisfaction. She thought she'd feel the warm glow of justice served cold, with a side of schadenfreude and a dash of "I told you so." Instead, she felt something else. Something that felt like — no. She did not feel bad for him. She could not feel bad for him.

"You got what you deserved," she said.

"I did," Leo said. He didn't argue. He just sat there, looking at the coffee she'd slid across the counter, and took a sip. It was the same Ethiopian Yirgacheffe he'd had yesterday. He closed his eyes again. Opened them. Looked at the cup with the same expression of personal betrayal. "Can I have another?"

"No."

"Please."

"I — no."

"You're being petty."

"I'm being a business owner who has fourteen thousand dollars of beans arriving and a lease that's about to get interesting and a coffee shop that's one bad month away from becoming a boutique candle

store."

Leo's eyebrows went up. "Fourteen thousand dollars of beans."

"How did you —"

"Bean & Leaf orders in bulk. I know what a five-hundred-pound order looks like. That's the kind of order that's either a very committed wedding or a very bad business decision."

"It was a business decision," Maya said. "It was a very bad business decision."

Leo sat in silence for a moment. Then he said, "I need a job."

"I don't hire ex-enemy agents."

"You don't hire anyone. You have one employee who's also your best friend and who you pay in scones."

"It's a great scone."

"I'm good at supply chains," Leo said. "I know the import market. I know which roasters are lying about their sourcing and which ones are actually good. I know how to move inventory without getting stuck with it."

Maya said nothing.

"I'm free starting today. I have no income. I have an apartment that I can't afford. I have a resume that says 'acquisitions director at Bean & Leaf' and a reputation in the industry that starts with 'oh, the guy who got fired.'"

"You got me fired," Maya said. "Sort of. Indirectly."

"In a very roundabout way, yes. And for that I'm sorry. I'm also here to work off my debt. Literally. I'll work for free. I'll stock shelves. I'll clean the espresso machine. I'll sort the beans. I'll do anything."

Maya looked at him. He was sincere. He was not smiling. He was not charming her. He was offering to do manual labor for a woman whose business he'd been hired to destroy, because somehow, in the three minutes they'd spent talking about coffee, he'd decided that her shop was more real than the company he'd worked for.

It was, she thought, the most corporate thing he could possibly do. And also the least.

"You can't work for free," she said. "I don't need charity."

"I'm not offering charity. I'm offering a deal. You need the beans sold. I know how to sell beans. I'll work for three weeks. If we hit the target, you pay me. If we don't, I leave."

"Three weeks," Maya said. "Fourteen thousand dollars in three weeks."

"Yeah."

"That's impossible."

"Not with the right strategy. You've got a loyal customer base. You just don't have the reach. I do. Or —" he paused, "I did. Before I got fired."

Maya looked at him. She looked at the espresso machine hissing in the background. She looked at the Mystery Bean lottery idea still scribbled on a notepad behind the register, a gleam of a plan that was both terrible and somehow exactly what this situation needed. She looked at the door where Mrs. Hsu had left, and she thought about what Mrs. Hsu had said about Bean & Leaf expanding, and she thought about how she'd been fighting this war alone for three years.

She thought about the bell above the door, which had jingled twice already this afternoon, and she realized that the shop was, in some small way, responding. The shop wanted help. The shop was asking for it. The shop had been asking for it the entire time, and Maya had been too proud to hear it.

"You start tomorrow," she said.

Leo smiled. It was the real smile again. The one that made the corners of his eyes crinkle. "Thank you."

"Don't thank me. I'm not doing this because I like you. I'm doing this because I need fourteen thousand dollars and you're the only person in this city who knows how to sell beans without sounding like a press release."

"Fair enough," Leo said. "Can I get that second cup?"

"I'll make it," Maya said. "But I'm charging you full price."

"Worth it."

She made the coffee. She handed it to him across the counter. Their fingers brushed. The moment lasted exactly one second, but in that second, Maya felt something she hadn't felt in a long time — the particular electric jolt of contact with someone who wasn't trying to sell her anything.

Leo took the cup. "See you tomorrow," he said.

He left.

Maya stood in the doorway and watched him walk down the street in his navy suit, carrying a paper cup of her coffee like it was something precious.

She closed the door. Locked it. Leaned against it.

"You're making a mistake," she told herself.

"I know," said the part of her that had already decided it wasn't.

End of Chapter 3

Chapter 4 — Mrs. Hsu's Coaster

Maya had never been fired. She had never been hired, technically — she'd bought the shop, which meant she'd hired herself, which meant she could fire herself but she never would because she needed the health insurance. The closest she'd come to professional humiliation was the time a customer had asked for a cortado and she'd made a latte and then claimed it was "an artistic interpretation and also it was still four dollars."

She had not been enjoying Leo's company the previous afternoon. She had, in fact, been actively resenting it. The fact that he'd shown up this morning at 6:30 a.m., ten minutes before opening, wearing a white shirt that was slightly too big and carrying a clipboard he'd apparently purchased at a drugstore on the way, did not improve her mood.

"I made a list," he said.

Maya stared at him over the espresso machine. "A list."

"Of things we can do with five hundred pounds of Ethiopian Yirgacheffe in thirty days. I've broken it into three phases. Phase one: immediate sales. Phase two: community events. Phase three: viral moments."

Maya's jaw clicked. "Viral moments."

"It's a strategy, not a lifestyle."

"It's a lifestyle for people who say 'strategy' in meetings."

Leo ignored this. He unfolded the clipboard and revealed a spreadsheet that was, Maya had to admit, extremely well-organized. Columns. Dates. Numbers. Colors she didn't understand but that looked important.

"Where did you get this?" she asked.

"Bean & Leaf. I had thirty minutes after the firing email before security escorted me out. I printed everything I could about our supply chain relationships. African exporters, West Coast roasters, the Seattle distribution hub that Bean & Leaf uses and that I can't use anymore because I'm excommunicated."

"Excommunicated."

"Corporate fired. Same thing. Look — I know five roasters who need small-batch Ethiopian and can't get it because Bean & Leaf locked down the best contracts. I know three events happening in the next two weeks where coffee professionals will pay a premium for single-origin. I know a guy at the Saturday market who sells coffee out of a trailer and whose customers would buy beans from us just

because we're not Bean & Leaf."

Maya read the spreadsheet. It was good. It was actually good. The kind of good that made her hands twitch because she hadn't had another adult to share operational thinking with since Sam, and Sam thought spreadsheets were "spread sheets" and that was the extent of her knowledge.

"How much did you sleep last night?" Maya asked.

"None."

"That's not sustainable."

"This is a startup. Startups don't sleep."

"This is a coffee shop. We sleep. We have to. The espresso machine has a sleep mode."

Leo looked at the espresso machine with genuine curiosity, as though it were a living creature. "Does it dream about milk?"

"No," Maya said. "It dreams about being cleaned more often."

The morning rush hit before they could continue the conversation. Maya worked the machine. Leo stood beside her, watching, and occasionally said things like "you're tamping too hard" and "your grind size is inconsistent" and "you're wasting milk," and each comment was accurate and also made Maya want to throw a tamper at his head.

By 11:00 a.m., the rush had thinned to a murmur. Sam arrived, carrying a tote bag and the particular energy of someone who'd had a very good idea and was waiting for the right moment to share it.

"Did you see the Bean & Leaf flyers?" Sam asked, dropping the tote bag on a table.

Maya's stomach dropped. "Flyers."

Sam produced a crumpled piece of paper from the tote bag. It was glossy. It featured a photo of a white mug on a wooden table with a plant beside it and a person with good posture drinking from it. The headline read: "Ethical Sourcing, Elevated."

"They're hiring," Sam said. "Barista positions. Twelve dollars an hour."

"Twelve dollars," Maya said. "That's what we pay."

"Bean & Leaf pays twelve dollars with health insurance and a loyalty program."

Maya looked at the flyer. She looked at Leo, who'd gone quiet. He was staring at the floor. He'd known this was coming. He'd known Bean & Leaf was expanding, but this — this was personal. This was them walking into her neighborhood and stealing her staff with a glossy flyer and a promise of stability.

"We need to match it," Sam said.

"We don't have insurance," Maya said. "We don't have a loyalty program. We have a paper card that we hole-punch."

"We can make a loyalty program," Sam said. "We can make it better. We can make it digital. I have a friend who's a web developer. We can do QR codes."

"We can't afford a developer," Maya said.

"I'll do it. I can build a simple app. I've been learning React."

"Sam," Maya said gently, "you once tried to fix the espresso machine and broke the steam wand."

"That was one time. And I fixed it."

"You superglued the steam wand to the boiler."

"It held."

Maya looked at Leo. He was still quiet. She expected him to say something smooth, something corporate about "synergies" or "partnerships" or "why don't we just work together and solve this problem." She'd been bracing for it. She was ready to reject it.

Instead, Leo said, "I know the roaster they're using. I can get a better one. We can offer exclusive beans that Bean & Leaf can't get because they're locked into contracts. We can be the shop that actually has the good stuff."

"You're the person who got fired," Maya said.

"I'm the person who knows where the good stuff is."

Maya looked around the shop. She looked at the chalkboard menu with its smudged letters. She looked at the espresso machine that Leo had just taught her to calibrate better. She looked at Sam, who was bouncing on her heels with a t-shirt idea that Maya could already tell was terrible but also kind of brilliant. She looked at the door where Mrs. Hsu had stood, telling her that Bean & Leaf was buying the pharmacy, telling her to write a business plan, telling her that she was not alone in this fight even though she certainly felt like it.

She thought about the spreadsheet in Leo's hand. She thought about the fourteen thousand pounds of beans in the warehouse. She thought about the bell above the door that had stopped jingling for exactly thirty seconds and then started again, as if to remind her that the shop was still alive, still breathing, still waiting.

"Okay," she said.

Leo's head came up. "Okay?"

"Okay. Phase one of the spreadsheet. We start today. We sell ten pounds by the end of the week. Twenty pounds by the end of next week. We hit forty by the end of the month. We make the deadline."

"Forty pounds," Leo said, looking at his math. "That's — that's aggressive."

"I know. That's why I picked it."

Sam whooped. It was a sound that had once been described by a customer as "joyful but alarming." "I'll make the loyalty cards. Physical ones. Because physical is better. And I'll start posting on Instagram. Real posts. Not the curated bullshit. Real stuff. The burnt pastries. The weird customers. The fact that we're a coffee shop fighting a corporate war and we're winning because we have better beans."

"Sam," Maya said, "you can't say we're winning before we've won anything."

"We're already winning. Because we're trying," Sam said.

Leo closed the spreadsheet. He looked at Maya with an expression that was not the corporate smile and not the charming grin but something in between, something more honest, something that said "I don't believe in this either but I'm going to try." "I'll start calling the roasters."

"I'll start making better coffee," Maya said.

"And I'll start not breaking things," Sam said.

Maya laughed. It was a short, sharp sound that surprised her because it meant she was still capable of laughter even when her loan was due and her competition had just opened a store three blocks away and she'd just hired the man who'd been sent to destroy her.

The bell jingled. A customer walked in. Maya served them. Leo watched, and then he asked a question about her tamping technique, and Maya told him it was "a proprietary method," and Leo said he understood proprietary methods because he'd spent three years at Bean & Leaf pretending to care about corporate synergy, and Maya said she'd spent three years pretending to care about latte art, and they both looked at Sam, who said "I knew you two would get along. I'm getting nachos."

The morning continued. The espresso machine hissed. The fridge hummed its B-flat. The chalkboard menu stayed smudged. Maya served coffee, Leo watched, Sam ate scones, and for exactly four hours, the shop felt like something that might survive.

Not because of the spreadsheet. Not because of the plan. But because for the first time since she'd bought the place, Maya wasn't alone.

She had a partner. A partner she'd rather not have. A partner who was technically her enemy. A partner who was currently drinking her coffee and telling her tamping jokes and standing at her counter like he

belonged there.

He didn't belong there. She knew that. He knew that.

But the shop didn't seem to mind.

End of Chapter 4

Chapter 5 — The Almost-Kiss and the Espresso Explosion

By day seven of the partnership, Maya had developed a theory: Leo was not a bad person. He was a person who had made a series of bad decisions that had led him to a job he didn't want, in a company he didn't believe in, doing things that made him wake up at 3 a.m. and wonder how he'd ended up here.

This theory was based entirely on the fact that he'd shown up at 6:30 a.m. every day for a week, that he'd sorted three hundred pounds of green coffee beans into burlap sacks with the focused attention of someone defusing a bomb, and that he'd stopped wearing the navy suit.

The navy suit had been replaced, on day four, by a gray sweater that Maya vaguely recognized from a Gap she'd once been inside. The sweater had a coffee stain on the sleeve that he'd tried to hide but that Maya had pointed out immediately because Maya was the kind of person who noticed coffee stains the way a hawk noticed a field mouse.

The stain was from yesterday. Maya had thrown a handful of grounds at him during a playful argument about roast profiles. She regretted it. She also didn't.

"You're overthinking the grind," Leo said, on day eight.

They were standing at the espresso machine. Maya was making a latte. Leo was watching her with the particular intensity of someone who'd spent three years analyzing supply chains and had now redirected that energy toward analyzing tamping pressure.

"I am not overthinking the grind," Maya said. "You are overthinking the grind. You've been here for eight days and you've already commented on my grind eleven times."

"Your grind is inconsistent. On Monday it was too fine. On Tuesday it was too coarse. Today it's somewhere in between but trending toward fine, which will over-extract and make the latte bitter."

Maya finished the latte. She set it on the counter. She looked at Leo. She looked at the steam wand, which was currently hissing like a cat that had been surprised. She looked at the window, where the sun was doing that thing it did in Portland in June where it decided to show up for three hours and then leave like a guest who'd realized the party wasn't for them.

"Let's do a cupping," she said.

Leo blinked. "A cupping."

"A cupping. You know. Where we taste different roasts and compare notes and see who has the better palate."

Leo smiled. It was a dangerous smile. The kind of smile that suggested he knew something she didn't, or that he'd been waiting for exactly this challenge. "You're on."

They moved to the back room, to the small table where Maya usually did paperwork and Sam usually ate lunch. Maya laid out five small glass cups on a tray, each with a different roast, and placed a silver spoon beside each one. She poured hot water over the grounds. The smell filled the room — rich and dark and alive, the kind of smell that made you want to close your eyes and just breathe.

"Start with the light roast," Maya said. "Work your way down."

Leo took the first cup. He slurped. He made a face. "Blueberry. Chocolate. A hint of — is that cedar?"

Maya's eyebrows went up. Cedar was a tasting note that appeared on exactly one bag in her inventory, and she'd never told anyone about it because the one person who'd asked had said "this tastes like a woodshop" and Maya had said "it's called terroir, Brenda, look it up."

"That's the Ethiopia," she said.

Leo nodded like he'd expected it. He moved to the second cup. Third. Fourth. Each time he got closer to the right notes. Each time Maya found herself leaning in, watching his face, reading his reactions.

By the fifth cup, the darkest roast, the one she called "Midnight," Leo was quiet. He took a sip. He held it. He swallowed slowly, like he was trying to catch something that was fleeing.

"What do you get?" Maya asked.

Leo opened his eyes. "You're not going to like it."

"Try me."

"Smoke. Bittersweet chocolate. And something underneath that tastes like the memory of fruit."

Maya stared at him. "The memory of fruit."

"Fruit that was there once and now is just a ghost."

"That's — that's exactly what I get."

Leo smiled. It was the smile again. The one that made Maya's stomach do the thing it had done yesterday when their fingers had brushed at the counter. "We make a good team," he said.

"Don't get cocky."

"I'm not being cocky. I'm being accurate. Your palate is exceptional. Most people taste 'coffee.' You taste the underneath."

There was a silence. The kind of silence that happened in rom-coms right before the almost-kiss. The kind of silence that involved leaning, and hesitation, and the sound of a refrigerator humming in the background, and a feeling in Maya's chest that was like when you missed a step on the stairs — not falling, just the moment before.

Leo leaned in. Maya leaned in.

The refrigerator door swung open.

A carton of oat milk fell out. It hit the floor with a sound that was less of a crash and more of a betrayed sigh.

They both jumped. Leo stumbled. Maya laughed — she couldn't help it. It came out as a snort, which was humiliating, but Leo laughed too, and suddenly they were both standing in the back room of a coffee shop on Alberta Street, covered in oat milk, laughing like they'd just won something that they hadn't known was a contest.

"That," Maya said, wiping her eyes, "is the least romantic thing that has ever happened to me."

"It's memorable," Leo said.

"It's a refrigerator."

"Refrigerators are underrated," Leo said. "That fridge just saved us from a moment that would have been awkward in about three different ways."

"How so?"

"Well," Leo said, and his voice dropped just slightly, "if we'd kissed, I would have thought it meant something. And you would have panicked. And we would have had to navigate that the next day while sorting beans. And we don't have time for that. We have a business to run."

Maya's smile faltered. He was right. She would have panicked. She would have spent the next week avoiding eye contact, and they'd lose momentum on the bean sale, and everything would fall apart.

"I appreciate the refrigerator's tactical intervention," she said.

"Appliances are tactical," Leo said. "They see things we don't."

Sam walked in at that moment. She took in the scene: Maya and Leo, side by side, covered in oat milk, laughing. The open refrigerator. The spilled carton on the floor.

"...did I miss something?" Sam asked.

"The refrigerator saved us from ourselves," Maya said.

"Of course it did. Fridge is a legend. Can I have a scone?"

"Help yourself," Maya said. "But you're cleaning the milk."

"Already on it."

Sam knelt to clean the milk. Maya looked at Leo. He looked at her. There was no more leaning. There was just work. But under the work, under the spreadsheet and the supply chain and the five hundred pounds of Ethiopian beans and the three weeks they had to sell them, there was something else. Something that had started with an argument about pour-over and had become, somehow, a partnership that felt like walking on a balance beam — terrifying and exhilarating and requiring every ounce of attention.

The bell jingled. The day continued. Maya made coffee. Leo watched. Sam ate a scone.

And somewhere in the back of Maya's mind, the refrigerator was watching too.

End of Chapter 5

Chapter 6 — Lotteries and Lies

The Mystery Bean Lottery launched on a Friday.

Maya had designed the tickets herself. She'd printed them on the shop's creaky inkjet printer, which had survived three years of menu printing and was now being asked to produce two hundred tiny lottery tickets with enough resilience to survive pockets and purses. The tickets said "COFFEE RINGS AND BAD DECISIONS — MYSTERY BEAN LOTTERY" in her handwriting, which Sam called "charming" and which a customer had once asked if it was a "cry for help."

It was, Maya admitted to herself, kind of both.

The tickets went on sale at 8:00 a.m. The first one was bought by a regular named Dave, who paid with exact change and then spent ten minutes debating whether he should buy a second one because "the odds seem good" and Maya had to explain that the odds were actually terrible because there were only twenty winning tickets out of two hundred, which was not good odds at all, but Dave bought another ticket anyway because he was a man who believed in fortune more than mathematics.

By 10:00 a.m., they'd sold sixty tickets.

By noon, one hundred and twenty.

By 2:00 p.m., all two hundred tickets were gone.

Maya stood behind the counter, holding a wad of cash that was thicker than she'd expected, and stared at it like it might bite. "Fourteen hundred dollars," she said.

"Not fourteen thousand," Sam said, standing beside her with a handful of leftover tickets that she was using as a fan. "But it's a start. We need seven more of these days. We need a viral moment."

"We need a miracle," Maya said.

"We need a TikTok," Sam said.

Maya had never made a TikTok. She didn't own TikTok. She owned Instagram, which she updates irregularly and which she'd once described as "a digital garden where I plant photos of coffee and wait for strangers to appreciate it." Sam had said that wasn't how Instagram worked. Maya had said she didn't care how Instagram worked. She cared about coffee.

Now, apparently, she needed a TikTok.

"Who's making the TikTok?" Maya asked.

"I am," Sam said. "It's going to be called 'Coffee Shop vs. Bean & Leaf: The Battle for Alberta Street.' It's going to have dramatic music and text overlays and a part where I throw beans at the camera."

"That sounds —"

"Viral?"

"It sounds like Sam making a TikTok."

"Same thing."

The lottery money was in the register, but Maya knew it wasn't enough. The bean order was four weeks. They had three weeks to sell it. Fourteen thousand dollars in twenty-one days. The math was bad. The math was terrible. The math was the kind of math that made her want to close the shop, move to the woods, and live on mushrooms and silence.

Instead, she opened the laptop and started planning.

Leo arrived at 6:30 a.m. the next day. He was wearing a sweater now. The navy suit was gone. He looked like a normal person, which was somehow more alarming because normal people had normal problems, and Leo had just exited a corporate job under dramatic circumstances, which meant he was about as normal as a raccoon in a tuxedo.

"I have a contact at the coffee festival," he said.

Maya looked up. They were in the back room, surrounded by sacks. The smell of green coffee was so strong it was becoming a personality. "You have a contact."

"Bean & Leaf was going to have a booth at the Portland Coffee Festival this weekend. We got canceled. The organizer still has the slot. I asked if we could take it."

Maya stared at him. "You asked?"

"I asked. She said yes. We can have a booth for two hundred dollars. We can sell beans, do tastings, hand out flyers. It's exactly the kind of exposure we need."

"Two hundred dollars," Maya said.

"The festival draws five thousand people. Coffee professionals. Journalists. People who actually care about where their beans come from. It's the perfect venue."

Maya thought about the fourteen thousand dollars. She thought about the two weeks they had. She thought about the lottery money, which had been a great start but wasn't going to finish the race.

"We don't have two hundred dollars for a booth," she said.

Leo produced a check from his pocket. It was personal. Leo Bianchi. No company letterhead. The amount was two hundred and twelve dollars. "I've got booth fees covered. Consider it an investment in my own survival."

Maya looked at the check. She looked at Leo. She felt the familiar resistance — the desire to say no, to reject his help, to prove she could do this alone. But the words wouldn't come. Because she couldn't do this alone. She'd been doing it alone for three years, and alone had gotten her a loan and a declining business and a caffeine-fueled email that had nearly sunk her.

"Fine," she said. "But you're doing the booth setup. I'm not waking up early for a trade show."

"I wouldn't dream of it," Leo said.

He smiled. Maya didn't smile back. She thought about the refrigerator. She thought about the almost-kiss that hadn't happened because the fridge had intervened like a *deus ex machina* made of dairy. She thought about the way her chest felt when he looked at her with that particular combination of earnestness and wit.

"You're paying for the booth," she said. "But I'm choosing the coffee we serve at the festival. And we're not doing the Mystery Bean lottery there. That's a disaster waiting to happen."

"Agreed," Leo said. "We're serving the Yirgacheffe. Black on black. No gimmicks."

Maya nodded. It was the right call. The Yirgacheffe was the good stuff. The festival was the right crowd. They could sell forty pounds in two days if they worked it right.

She just hoped they wouldn't accidentally fall in love while doing it.

End of Chapter 6

Chapter 7 — The Festival

The Portland Coffee Festival occupied the brick courtyard behind a brewery on East Burnside. It was the kind of event where people wore bean-shaped earrings and discussed acidity like it was a personality trait and where someone, every year, attempted to pour latte art that was also a portrait of their dog.

Maya had been once. She'd gone as a customer, not a vendor. She'd stood in the crowd with a paper cup of Ethiopian and watched the roasters and the baristas and the people with the branded tents and thought, one day, that would be her.

Now she was standing behind a table with a banner that said "COFFEE RINGS AND BAD DECISIONS" in Sam's handwriting, and Leo was beside her in a clean sweater, and she was serving coffee to strangers and hoping none of them were from Bean & Leaf.

"Relax," Leo said. "Bean & Leaf isn't here. I told the organizer we'd take their slot. They didn't want it anyway."

"Are you sure?"

"I'm sure. I'm also banned from the Bean & Leaf booth area. Security escorted me. It was dramatic."

Maya imagined it. She tried not to smile. "Was it dignified?"

"I've had worse Tuesdays."

The crowd arrived at eleven. It was the kind of crowd that made Maya's heart both full and nervous — people who cared about coffee, who knew the difference between a natural and a washed process, who could identify a grapefruit note from across a room. These were not the casual drinkers who came for the free Wi-Fi. These were the initiates.

And they liked her coffee.

"Where's this from?" a woman asked, holding a cup of the Yirgacheffe.

"Ethiopia," Maya said. "Single-origin. Small lot. I source it directly."

"Direct trade?"

"Direct trade."

The woman nodded. She bought two bags. She gave Maya her business card. She said she was a buyer at a café in Sellwood and she wanted to carry Maya's beans.

Maya looked at the card. She looked at Leo. Leo was grinning.

"Direct trade," Leo said quietly. "You're killing it."

"I'm not killing it. I'm surviving it."

"Surviving is killing it when you have five hundred pounds of Ethiopian beans and a booth fee that I paid for."

Maya served the next customer. Then the next. By 2:00 p.m., they'd sold twenty-two pounds. By 4:00 p.m., thirty-one pounds. The booth had turned into a small ecosystem — a regular stream of people, most of whom came back for seconds, some of whom asked questions, a few of whom took cards and said they'd be in touch.

At 5:00 p.m., a man in a blazer stopped at the booth. He was carrying a Bean & Leaf tote bag. Maya's stomach dropped.

"Leo Bianchi," the man said. "I wondered if I'd find you here."

Maya tensed. This was it. Bean & Leaf had sent an emissary. This was how they destroyed her — quietly, publicly, with a smile and a handshake.

"Rachel," Leo said. The name was not a greeting. It was a warning.

Rachel Maitland had been Leo's boss. She was wearing a blazer that cost more than Maya's car. She had a smile that had been calibrated in a boardroom and a stare that could peel bark off a tree.

"Leo," she said. "I see you found a new home."

"She found me," Leo said. "I'm helping her sell her beans."

Rachel turned to Maya. Her smile softened, which was somehow worse. "Maya Chen. Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions. I've heard good things. Your Ethiopian is excellent. We tried to buy your lot last quarter."

Maya straightened. "You what."

"We tried to acquire your supply chain. You turned us down."

"Because you offered to pay me twelve cents a pound while you charge customers twelve dollars a bag."

Rachel's smile didn't waver. "Supply chains are complicated. We offered what the market would bear."

"The market would bear more if you weren't cornering it."

Rachel paused. She looked at the crowd — the people buying Maya's coffee, the ones holding their phones, the ones whispering to each other about the booth that wasn't Bean & Leaf. She looked at the

banner. She looked at Maya.

"You're good at this," Rachel said. It was not a compliment. It was an assessment.

"Thank you."

Rachel turned back to Leo. "We'll talk," she said, and she walked away.

Maya felt her hands shaking. She put them on the counter. She looked at Leo. "What did she mean, we'll talk?"

Leo stared after Rachel. His jaw was tight. "She means she wants something."

"What kind of something?"

"Not a good something," Leo said.

The hours stretched. They sold more beans. The festival closed. They packed up, loaded the car, drove back to the shop, and counted the cash in the back room.

Forty-three pounds sold.

Four thousand dollars in one day.

Maya sat on the floor of the back room, surrounded by empty burlap sacks and coffee cups, and laughed. It was a real laugh this time. Not the sharp bark from before, not the snort from the refrigerator incident, but a full, exhausted, disbelieving laugh that came from somewhere deep in her chest.

"We're not dead," she said.

"Not yet," Leo agreed.

He sat beside her on the floor. They were shoulder to shoulder, surrounded by the ruins of a very successful day. The air smelled like coffee and triumph and, faintly, the oat milk that had never fully cleaned from the refrigerator.

"We should get a drink," Leo said.

Maya blinked. "What."

"A drink. To celebrate. Not coffee. Something else. Something with less coffee in it."

Maya considered. She thought about the spreadsheet. She thought about the fourteen thousand dollars, which now felt slightly less impossible. She thought about the almost-kiss that had been interrupted by a refrigerator, and the way she'd laughed at it, and the way she'd wanted to lean in again.

"A drink," she said. "Fine. But I'm picking the place."

"Where are we going?"

Maya stood. She offered Leo a hand. He took it. The contact lasted longer this time — just long enough for Maya to feel the warmth of his hand, the slight roughness of his palm from handling burlap sacks, the particular electricity that had nothing to do with caffeine and everything to do with the fact that they were two people who'd accidentally become partners in a business that shouldn't have worked but somehow did.

"Somewhere," Maya said, pulling him up, "that doesn't serve coffee."

Leo smiled. "Lead the way."

End of Chapter 7

Chapter 8 — TikTok, Torrents, and Leo's Bad Hand

The drink was at a bar on Alberta called The Record Room, which had a jukebox full of vinyl and a bartender named Jules who remembered everyone's order and who'd once told Maya that her espresso was "better than anything I can make in a cup" and Maya had framed the compliment mentally and lived off it for six months.

They sat at the bar. Leo drank a negroni. Maya drank a negroni because she was tired of being predictable. The first sip was terrible. The second sip was interesting. By the third, she was describing her business model to Jules in detail.

"We have fourteen thousand pounds of beans," Maya said.

"Pounds," Jules said, wiping a glass.

"Pounds. Fourteen thousand dollars of beans. Twenty-one days to sell them. We've sold forty-three pounds in one day. Do the math."

Jules did the math. He shook his head. "You're behind."

"I know. We're behind. But we got a boost. The festival. Leo's spreadsheet. Leo being Leo, apparently."

Leo winced. "Being Leo isn't a market advantage."

"It is right now. Your spreadsheet saved us."

"I'm not a spreadsheet," Leo said. "I'm a person."

"Your spreadsheet is very personable."

Leo laughed. The sound was different in the bar — softer, less strategic, more like the laugh of someone who'd forgotten, for a moment, that they'd been fired three days ago.

Maya liked that laugh. She liked it more than she should.

"Tell me about Bean & Leaf," she said.

Leo's smile faltered. "What about it."

"You know their supply chain. You know their secrets. Was it always so — corporate?"

Leo took a sip of the negroni. He looked at the jukebox, which was playing something that sounded like a song from 1974 that had been waiting forty years to be heard again. "Bean & Leaf started with good intentions. The founder, Tom, he actually cared about coffee. He was a roaster. He'd been in the

industry for twenty years. He believed in direct trade before direct trade was a buzzword."

"What happened?"

"VC money."

Maya nodded. She knew the story. It was the same story that happened to every good idea that got close enough to a venture capitalist to smell like money. "They scaled. The vision got diluted. The founder got pushed out. The people who replaced him cared about growth, not coffee."

"Bingo," Leo said. "Tom got fired two years ago. He's running a small roastery in Bend now. He sends me emails sometimes. He sends me coffee. He's the one who told me about the Yirgacheffe lot — the one Bean & Leaf locked down. That's how I knew you had the good stuff."

Maya thought about this. She thought about Tom in Bend, sending coffee to the man who'd been fired for defending a small shop. She thought about how the industry was full of people like Tom, people who cared but who'd been pushed out by people who didn't.

Leo was not like Tom. Leo had compromised. Leo had worked for Bean & Leaf for three years, had taken the severance, had tried to survive. But he'd also quit. He'd also stood in Maya's shop and asked for a job and had meant it.

"We're not selling," Maya said.

Leo looked at her. "Selling what."

"The shop. Bean & Leaf offered. Indirectly. Through Rachel. She came to the festival and dropped hints. I'm not selling. Not now. Not ever."

Leo was quiet for a moment. Then he said, "Good."

"Good?"

"Good. Because if you sold, I'd have to find another coffee shop to work at, and I like yours. The espresso machine has personality."

Maya laughed. She laughed because it was a strange, genuine thing to say. She laughed because she was sitting in a bar with a man who'd been her enemy three weeks ago, drinking negronis, talking about coffee, and feeling something that she couldn't name but that was warm and real and not at all like the loneliness she'd been living with for three years.

"I have a question," she said.

"Shoot."

"Are you going to stay?"

Leo's face changed. Not much. Just a tightening around the eyes, a small recalculation. "Stay where."

"In the shop. After the beans are sold. After the three weeks. Are you going to stay."

Leo was quiet. The jukebox changed songs. Jules was wiping glasses, listening with the attentiveness of someone who'd heard a thousand conversations and had learned to read people like menus.

"Three weeks is the deal," Leo said.

"The deal was three weeks. I'm asking about after."

Leo took a breath. "I don't know. The Seattle job —"

"The Seattle job is in Seattle."

"It pays well."

"So does selling coffee. Eventually."

"It's not about the money."

"It's about what?"

Leo didn't answer immediately. He looked at the negroni in his glass. He looked at Maya. There was something in his eyes that Maya recognized — the particular conflict of someone who wanted two things that were in opposite directions, who was trying to choose between safety and something harder and more real.

"I've been playing it safe," he said. "For three years. I took the job at Bean & Leaf because it was the safe move. I stayed because it was the safe move. I let them fire me because I stopped caring, which was also a kind of safe, because I'd stopped fighting earlier."

"You're not playing it safe anymore," Maya said.

"No," Leo said. "I'm not."

He met her eyes. The silence stretched. Maya felt the pull again — the same pull she'd felt at the counter when their fingers had brushed, the same pull she'd felt in the back room before the refrigerator had saved them. It was the pull of proximity, of recognition, of two people who'd been alone for a long time and had accidentally found each other in the middle of a bean-selling emergency.

Jules slid another drink down the bar. Leo smiled. Maya didn't. She was too busy trying not to lean across the bar and kiss him, which was a terrible idea for at least seven reasons and a good idea for at least one reason that was currently winning.

"Another round?" Jules asked.

"Please," Maya said.

Leo smiled. He didn't lean across the bar. He didn't have to. The look he gave her said enough.

End of Chapter 8

Chapter 9 — The Buyout

The festival accelerated things. Not in the way Maya had hoped — she'd thought it would bring customers and cash — but in the way that momentum does when you're moving fast and not looking where you're going.

By the end of the second week, they'd sold ninety pounds of beans. Forty-three from the festival, another forty-seven from the shop, the parking lot, Sam's Instagram stories, and an impromptu cupping session that had accidentally turned into a pop-up at the Saturday market. Leo had called every roaster he knew. Maya had emailed every café within a twenty-mile radius. Sam had designed a loyalty card that was jazzy and colorful and had a coffee ring stain printed right on it because "authenticity."

They had five thousand dollars in the bank. They still needed ten thousand more, and they had six days to do it.

Maya was not sleeping.

"I think you should sell," her mother said.

Maya was on the phone. It was 10:00 p.m. She was sitting on the floor of the back room surrounded by sack labels. Her mother had called to ask how the coffee business was going, and Maya had told her about the festival and the ninety pounds and the loyalty cards, and her mother had gone quiet.

"Mom," Maya said.

"Fourteen thousand pounds," her mother said. "You can't sell fourteen thousand pounds of coffee in six days. You're twenty-nine years old. You don't have to prove anything. You can take the offer and walk away."

"I'm not walking away."

"Then what are you going to do?"

Maya looked at the spreadsheet Leo had made. She looked at the bean inventory, which had gone from five hundred pounds to four hundred and ten, which was technically progress but also a reminder of how far they still had to go.

"I'm going to finish it," she said.

"With what?"

"With Leo."

The silence on the other end of the line was the kind her mother did when she was measuring her words like coins. "Leo the ex-Bean & Leaf man."

"He's not ex-Bean & Leaf anymore. He's Leo."

"Leo who you met three weeks ago."

"Leo who knows things I don't know. Leo who has a brain that works like a supply chain and a heart that works like — like a person who cares. Leo who showed up at our shop at 6:30 a.m. every day for two weeks."

"You like him."

Maya flinched. "Mom."

"You liked him before I said anything. I can hear it in your voice. It's the same voice you used when you talked about Jake, and Jake was a disaster, and I liked him too."

"Jake was not a disaster. Jake was — Jake was complicated."

"Jake was an influencer who tried to put a ring light in your coffee shop."

Maya laughed. It was a bitter, affectionate sound. "Okay. Fine. Leo is complicated too. But he's — he's here. He's actually here."

"Where's Jake?"

Maya didn't answer. She couldn't. Because Jake was somewhere — maybe Los Angeles, maybe Bali, maybe at a coffee shop in Berlin that was going to be the subject of his next content series — and the thought of him didn't make her angry anymore or even sad. It just made her tired. She'd spent a year trying to be someone Jake wanted to film, and then she'd spent another year trying to be someone Maya wanted to be, and those two people had turned out to be very different.

"Mom," she said, "I have to go."

"Call me tomorrow."

"Tomorrow."

She hung up. She sat in the dark.

The bell jingled.

She looked up. Leo was standing in the doorway. He was holding a paper cup of coffee that was definitely not from a coffee shop — it was from the convenience store across the street, the one with the fluorescent lights and the pre-made sandwiches that Maya had once described as "food-shaped objects."

"Convenience store coffee," he said. "I know. I'm sorry."

"Sit," Maya said.

He sat. The refrigerator hummed. The floor creaked. The two of them sat in the dim light of the back room, surrounded by coffee sacks and the future of a business that shouldn't have been possible but somehow was.

"I got a call today," Leo said.

Maya's stomach dropped. "From whom."

"Rachel. She's offering to buy you out."

Maya went cold. "Buy me out."

"One hundred and fifty thousand dollars. For the shop, the equipment, the lease. She'll let you keep the name. She'll let you stay on as a consultant. You'd never have to make another cup of coffee if you didn't want to."

Maya said nothing.

Leo continued. "It's a good offer. The lease is cheap — Mrs. Hsu's rent — and the location is good. Bean & Leaf could turn it into something profitable."

"I don't want profits," Maya said. "I want the shop."

"Bean & Leaf isn't going to destroy the shop," Leo said. "They'll rebrand it. They'll keep the name. They'll keep the staff. They'll —"

"I don't care what they'll keep. I don't care what they'll change. This is mine. My grandmother left it to me. The paint on the walls is the color she chose. The espresso machine is the one she bought. The chalkboard menu is stained because she once dropped ink on it and I never fixed it."

Leo was quiet. "I know."

"Rachel knows that too. That's why she's offering. She wants the building because she knows it's not just a coffee shop. It's something that people care about." Maya's voice rose. "And you're sitting here telling me to take the offer because you don't believe I can sell fourteen thousand pounds of beans in six days."

"I'm telling you to consider it," Leo said. "Because I know what failure feels like. I've been watching you for three weeks, and I know how much this matters to you, and I know that failure is not an option. But sometimes — sometimes the right move isn't the heroic one."

Maya stood. "You don't get to decide what's heroic for me."

"I'm not deciding —"

"Yes, you are. You're sitting here with Bean & Leaf's money in your head, telling me what I should do, when what you should be doing is helping me figure out how to sell the remaining three hundred and seventy pounds of beans in six days, because that's the deal. That's the partnership. That's what we said."

"Maya —"

"I don't want to hear it. I don't want to hear about Bean & Leaf's generous offer. I don't want to hear about how they're going to 'preserve the brand.' I want to hear how we're going to sell these beans and prove to everyone — to Rachel, to the industry, to myself — that a coffee shop on Alberta Street with a chalkboard menu and a loyalty card from 1994 can out-compete a company with a Series B valuation and a design team."

Leo was silent.

"Leo," Maya said, softer now, "I don't need you to be the hero. I need you to be the person who knows how to sell coffee."

Leo looked at her for a long moment. Then he stood. He took the convenience store coffee, which had gone cold, and tossed it in the trash.

"I'll call Tom," he said.

Maya blinked. "Tom."

"Tom, the guy in Bend. The one who founded Bean & Leaf and who still has connections. He knows small roasters. He knows people who need beans. He'll help."

"Will he?"

"He will. Because I helped him when he left. And because he hates what Bean & Leaf has become."

Maya exhaled. She hadn't realized she'd been holding her breath. "Okay," she said. "Okay."

"Okay," Leo said.

He walked to the door. He paused. "I'm not trying to sell you out, Maya. I'm trying to keep you from hurting."

"I know," Maya said. But she didn't. She wasn't sure she would ever fully trust his motives, because trust was a slow-brew thing, not an espresso. It took time. They had six days.

"See you tomorrow," Leo said.

He left.

Maya stood in the back room, surrounded by coffee sacks, and felt the edges of her panic soften just a little. She thought about Tom in Bend. She thought about Leo, who was complicated and compromised and somehow still trying to do the right thing. She thought about the buyout offer, which was generous and tempting and everything she'd been afraid of when she'd first walked into this shop as a twenty-six-year-old with a dream and a credit card.

She was not selling.

She sat down at the laptop. She opened the spreadsheet. She started writing emails.

End of Chapter 9